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DMK promises homemakers ₹8,000 coupon for buying home appliances of choice

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Unveiling what he described as a “superstar” manifesto for the coming Tamil Nadu Assembly election, DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday promised a ₹8,000 coupon to all “non-Income Tax paying” homemakers to buy any electronic home appliance of their choice from the nearest stores.

The manifesto, released at the party headquarters Anna Arivalayam in Chennai, sought to strike a balance between welfare schemes backed by adequate financial support and serious political issues such as federalism, Centre-State relations, and the imposition of Hindi.

On the one hand, it promised to popularise the Justice Kurian Committee report on Centre-State re-



Poll bonanza: DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and other leaders releasing the manifesto in Chennai on Sunday. R. RAGU

lations, and on the other, it announced a host of incentives.

Claiming that the DMK’s manifesto had always been the “hero” of elections, Mr. Stalin said the *Illatharasi* scheme – which will allow homemakers to buy or replace household appliances – would be the “heroine” of the 2026 election. “The manifesto will enter the fray as a superstar,” he said.

Asked whether the government had the funds to support such a scheme, he

said similar doubts were raised in 2021, but the DMK government kept all its promises and also implemented schemes not promised in the manifesto.

He said the government would mobilise resources for the implementation of welfare schemes and infrastructure projects launched in the past five years and generate funds through special financial management measures.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 6

Iran warns against ground invasion amid talks in Pak.

‘Waiting for troops to set them on fire’, says Iran Speaker; Pak. says it will soon host U.S.-Iran talks after regional Ministers meet in Islamabad; meet a cover for U.S. to deploy more troops, says Iran

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD

Iranian forces were “waiting for the arrival of American troops on the ground to set them on fire and punish their regional partners forever”, Iran’s state media reported Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf as saying on Sunday while warning the U.S. against a ground invasion. The remarks came as Pakistan announced on Sunday that it will soon host talks between the U.S. and Iran.

“Pakistan is very happy that both Iran and the U.S. have expressed their confidence in Pakistan’s facilitation” of the talks, which will happen in the “coming days,” Foreign Minister Ishraq Dar said in a televised speech after top diplomats



Foreign Ministers of Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, and Turkiye meet in Islamabad on Sunday to discuss the West Asia situation. REUTERS

from regional countries met in Islamabad.

There was no immediate word from the U.S. or Iran.

Foreign Ministers of Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, and Egypt were in Islamabad on Sunday for talks without U.S. or Israeli participation in a push to broker an end to the month-long war.

Challenging times, says PM on West Asia crisis

NEW DELHI
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday, in his monthly *Mann Ki Baat* address, noted that the situation in West Asia had created “challenging times” and called for those “politicising” the issue to refrain from doing so.

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NEARBY



Thirumavalavan to contest T.N. Assembly polls

CHENNAI
VCK founder and Chidambaram MP Thol. Thirumavalavan sprung a surprise on Sunday by announcing that he would contest the Assembly election from the Kattumannarkoil (SC) constituency. **» PAGE 6**

Stalin to begin his campaign from Tiruvarur

CHENNAI
CM M.K. Stalin will launch his election campaign in Tiruvarur, the home town of his father and former CM M. Karunanidhi, on Tuesday. **» PAGE 6**

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 7

‘I am the candidate in all seats,’ says Mamata

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Urging the West Bengal electorate to have faith in her, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday said people should consider her as the candidate contesting all 294 seats of the State Assembly.

“Mothers and sisters, will you vote for us or not? Forget who is your candidate, I am the candidate everywhere. We will be the ones forming the government,” the Trinamool Congress chairperson told a gathering in Purulia district.

Party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee also made similar comments at a gathering in Murshida-



Mamata Banerjee

bad on Sunday when faced with slogans from the crowd expressing displeasure over candidate selection. “If anyone is dissatisfied with the candidate, then think that I, Abhishek Banerjee, am contesting from here,” he said.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10

BJP is the ‘A team’ of Kerala, says Modi at campaign meet

Abdul Latheef Naha
PALAKKAD

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday intensified the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)’s campaign for the April 9 Kerala Assembly election with a sharp attack on both the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the Opposition United Democratic Front (UDF) as he visited the southern State that has been out of bounds for the alliance.

Alleging that the two fronts had alternated in power for decades while “looting” the State through corruption and misgovernance, Mr. Modi said their politics had deprived the people of Kerala of resources, opportunities,



Narendra Modi

and growth. The Prime Minister alleged that both the UDF and the LDF were misleading the public by labelling each other the B-team of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). “That is an inadvertent admission by both fronts that the BJP is the real A team in Kerala,” he said.

Positioning the BJP-led

NDA as a decisive alternative, the Prime Minister said that an NDA government would advance the vision of a “Viksit Kerala,” promising faster development and measures to curb the emigration of educated youth by creating opportunities within the State. “It is Modi’s guarantee to you. The NDA’s guarantee is Modi’s guarantee,” he said while addressing a rally of all 12 NDA candidates from Palakkad district at Fort Grounds at 2 p.m., where a large crowd gathered braving the intense summer heat to attend the event.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10
‘DE-RISKING PEOPLE’ » PAGE 11

Workers hit as MGNREGS jobs dry up

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Nearly 12,000 workers under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) in Muzaffar-

pur district in Bihar have not received work for the past three to four months.

While the Union government has promised to continue the programme till the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika

Mission (VB-G RAM G) Act is rolled out, workers say the reality on ground is different with no clarity on implementation of the Act.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 12

Vijay to make electoral debut from Perambur and Tiruchi East; Aadhav Arjuna fielded in Villivakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president and actor C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday announced candidates for all 234 constituencies in Tamil Nadu and 30 constituencies in Puducherry for the Assembly elections scheduled for April. Mr. Vijay will make his electoral debut from two constituencies – Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchi East.

The DMK has nominated the incumbent, R.D. Shekar, in Perambur and in the AIADMK-led front, the constituency has been allocated to the PMK, led by Anbumani Ramadoss. In Tiruchi East, the DMK has fielded the incumbent,



On the march: TVK president and actor C. Joseph Vijay and other leaders of the party at an event to announce the candidates for the Assembly election in Chennai on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Inigo Irudayaraj, while the AIADMK has put up K. Rajasekaran.

TVK general secretary ‘Bussy’ N. Anand is contesting from T. Nagar in Chennai, where Raja Anbazhagan of the DMK and B. Sathyanarayanan of the AIADMK are in the fray.

K.A. Sengottaiyan, a nine-time former AIADMK MLA who joined the TVK a few months ago, will contest from his home-turf, Gobichettipalayam. His supporter and former Tiruppur MP V. Sathyabama is contesting from Tiruppur North. Ku.Pa. Krishnan, a

former AIADMK Minister, is contesting from Lalgudi.

Another interesting contest will unfold in Villivakkam, where the TVK has fielded its general secretary (election campaign management) Aadhav Arjuna. The incumbent DMK MLA of Anna Nagar, M.K. Mohan’s son Karthik Mohan, and the AIADMK’s former Chennai Central MP, S.R. Vijayakumar, are contesting from Villivakkam.

TVK general secretary (policy and propaganda) K.G. Arunraaj is contesting from Tiruchengode, while joint general secretary C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar is contesting from Thirupparankundram. Treasurer P. Venkataramanan is seek-

ing election from Mylapore and former AIADMK MLA J.C.D. Prabhakar from Thousand Lights.

Former MLA V.S. Babu is contesting from Kolathur, where DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin is seeking election for the fourth time. D. Selvam, who was the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee general secretary and joined the TVK two days ago, will take on DMK youth wing secretary and Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin in Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni.

The deputy general secretaries, M. Arul Prakasham and A. Rajmohan, are contesting from Saidapet and Egmore (Reserved), respectively.

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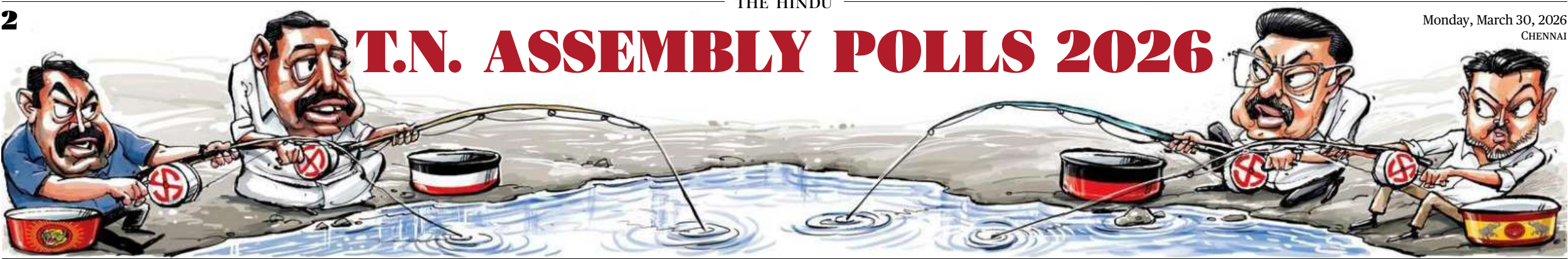
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A CH-CE



Partymen helping M.G. Ramachandran, recovering from gunshot wounds at a hospital, prepare his nomination papers for the 1967 Assembly election.

The charismatic leader who won his first and last elections from hospital bed

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

Matinee idol and former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran (MGR) must be the only person to have won his first and last elections to the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly from hospital bed. In his biography on R.M. Veerappan – *RMV Oru Thondar* (A cadre) – Rani Maindhan recalls the 1967 Assembly election that put the DMK in the seat of power for the first time.

MGR was chosen to contest from St. Thomas Mount (Parangimalai), one of the biggest constituencies in Tamil Nadu, and fortress of the Congress. Starting from Tiruvannmiyur, it sprawled over villages on the OMR, Pallavaram Municipality and parts of Tambaram.

“MGR had finished his first round of campaign when he was shot by M.R. Radha,” says R. Kannan, MGR’s biographer. He was hospitalised for two months. In February, MGR issued a statement from hospital bed, stating the Congress rule had brought only tears to people. Soon, posters bearing MGR’s image with a bandaged neck and folded palms seeking votes were pasted everywhere in the State, he says in his book *MGR: A life*.

Meanwhile, an election rule had been introduced making it mandatory for the candidate to come in person to file the affidavit. But, a request was made for election officials to visit MGR at the hospital and surprisingly, an exception was made.

As MGR could not travel for campaign, RMV consulted with the actor’s elder brother M.G. Chakkarapani. They convinced MGR to agree to a photo to be used for campaign, according to RMV’s biography. The charismatic star reluctantly agreed. Despite commotion and violence ahead of the elections, MGR won by a margin of 27,000 votes.

In 1984, MGR was hospitalised in Apollo Hospitals, Chennai, and then flown to Brooklyn State Hospital in New York. Meanwhile, elections to Parliament and Tamil Nadu Assembly were announced to be held in December. MGR, who could neither speak nor sign, filed his nomination for the Andipatti constituency in the presence of the Indian consul general in New York.

Video campaign

Following his surgery, MGR’s recovery was quick. His mind was agile and politically aware, says Mr. Kannan in his biography. From his hospital bed, he carefully followed the happenings back home. His routine was to read the newspapers thoroughly and surf the television. Meanwhile, back home, the Opposition maintained that MGR was dead and preserved in an icebox and the public was buying this argument, he notes.

One day, RMV convened a press conference at the Secretariat in Madras and released pictures of MGR showing the two leaves symbol, his wife Janaki Ramachandran by his side. The press had a field day. But, the Opposition countered saying they were all shot in Apollo Hospitals. With a few days to polling, RMV came up with another brilliant idea. Palani G. Periasamy, who was with MGR and his wife, shot a video and sent it across. There was a technical glitch. RMV sought the help of AVM Saravanan, his friend and film producer. M.S. Guhan, Saravanan’s son, flew to Singapore to convert the tape into a playable format here.

Along with Valampuri John’s narration, the video was released in over 100 theatres and screened across Tamil Nadu, according to RMV’s biography. AIADMK won easily and MGR became the Chief Minister again.

“MGR was naturally a charismatic man. He connected to the people easily. At times of natural disasters and wars, he was the first and largest contributor to the cause. He had too good an image,” says Mr. Kannan.

Promises delivered and undelivered during 5 years of DMK government

The govt. introduced schemes that did not figure in its manifesto, even while delivering key assurances such as *Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam* and free bus travel; but it has not formulated the Higher Education policy, set up Kalaigarn Canteens or created special courts for corruption cases

IN FOCUS
D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

In the past five years, the M.K. Stalin government had implemented several welfare schemes with far-reaching impact that helped uplift the lives of women as well as other sections.

It delivered on its key poll promises such as the *Kalaigarn Magalir Urimai Thittam* that entitled 1.31 crore women heads of families to receive a monthly rights grant of ₹1,000 and the *Vidiyal Payanam* scheme allowing women to travel with ‘zero cost’ bus tickets in select routes.

At the same time, the government introduced schemes that did not figure in its manifesto. This included empowering schemes such as *Pudhumai Penn*, *Tamil Pudhalvan*, *Naan Mudhalvan*, *Illam Thedi Kalvi*, *Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam*, and *Thayumanavar*.

But how many of the 505 promises the DMK made in 2021 have been fulfilled? The party leaders have made varying claims about this in the past. Some leaders claimed 90% of them had been honoured.

However, earlier this month, Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu, officially, in the presence of the Chief Minister, announced 75% promises were either fulfilled or being fulfilled.

As for the breakdown, he said 206 promises had been fulfilled, 170 were being implemented, and 32 were under the consideration of the State government, while 33 were pending with the Union government. As many as 20 promises were dropped “as not feasible”. The Minister, however, did not mention which of them were found unfeasible.

A perusal of the 2021 manifesto, however, threw up some significant promises that were either not fulfilled or only partially addressed.

Promise No. 3 in the manifesto read: “DMK in its efforts to oppose the National Education Policy introduced by the BJP government will formulate a separate State Education Policy for Tamil Nadu. To achieve this goal, a high-level committee comprising various educationists and other experts will be established.” The government did constitute the Justice Murugesan Committee. However, it released only the Tamil Nadu School



Poll vows: DMK president M.K. Stalin releasing the poll manifesto in 2021. Of the 505 promises, 75% were either fulfilled or being fulfilled, Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu said earlier this month.

Education Policy 2025, while the Higher Education Policy is yet to be formulated.

Horticulture University A Horticulture University (No. 53) in Krishnagiri and Agriculture University in Madurai (No. 54) are still on paper. A separate reservation of 2.5% (No. 332) for students from government-aided schools in medical colleges was not implemented.

The promise No. 159 that the government will repay graduate education loans for students from

schools in Tamil Nadu, under 30 years of age, who are unable to pay it back within a year, was also not taken forward.

The government did not execute the assurance to establish Kalaigarn Canteens (No. 331) in 500 locations in the first phase to provide food at a subsidised cost for poor, underprivileged people across the State.

As for battling corruption, the DMK promised to establish special courts (No. 21) to handle corruption cases against former AIADMK Ministers and ex-

pedite its function. But the DVAC only registered cases against some former Ministers.

The government also did not take any steps to introduce a legislation to reserve 75% of the private sector jobs for locals (No. 196). The DMK had also said priority would be given to first generation graduates in government jobs (No. 179).

While it had promised to restore the Old Pension Scheme (No. 309), the government walked a tight rope; found a *via media* and introduced the Tamil

Nadu Assured Pension Scheme.

Among the most populist promises, the government was unable to fulfil its assurance of giving ₹100 as cooking gas cylinder subsidy (No. 503) to ration cardholders. It did not reduce the price of diesel by ₹4 per litre (No. 504).

While as part of the same promise, it had promised to cut petrol price by ₹5 per litre, the government actually slashed it by ₹3 (state excise duty).

Nonetheless, the government fulfilled its promise (No. 505) to reduce the price of Aavin milk by ₹3 per litre.

Its other populist promise that remains unkept is to introduce a monthly payment of electricity bills (No. 221). The DMK manifesto had said, “The existing system of bimonthly payment of electricity bills will be replaced with a monthly payment system to ease the financial burden on people. This scheme will enable a user household to save up to ₹6,000 (for <1000 units) annually.”

While the DMK promised it would get NEET-based medical admissions abolished (No. 160), it could not fulfil it despite passing a Bill twice, as the President withheld assent.

How close contests impacted victory margins in past Assembly elections

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

While Tamil Nadu is heading for a four-cornered contest in the upcoming Assembly election, an analysis of the poll results since 1967 shows there were occasions where candidates lost by fewer than 25 votes.

In 1967, when the DMK became the country’s first regional party to capture power, the outcome in 17 Assembly seats was decided by less than 1,000 votes. In Vanur (Reserved) seat, DMK’s Balakrishnan defeated Congress’s Velayudham by 70 votes.

In 1971, when early polls were held against the backdrop of the 1969 split in the Congress, M. Karunanidhi returned to power. In 11 seats, the victory margin was below 1,000 votes. In Sankarapuram, N. Natchiyappan (DMK) defeated Duraimuthusamy (INC-O) by 72 votes.

In the 1977 election, when the AIADMK, founded by M.G. Ramachandran, swept to power in a four-cornered contest, 24 candidates were elected with margins of below 1,000 votes. In Taramangalam, S. Semmalai (AIADMK) lost to R. Narayanan (Congress) by just 19 votes. Congress’s N. Sundararaj defeated AIADMK’s P. Ponnambalam in Thirumayam by 57 votes.

In the 1980 mid-term poll, when MGR returned to power, the margin in 24 seats was below 1,000. CPI’s S. Sivasamy won Ilayankudi, narrowly defeating DMK’s V. Malaikannan by 56 votes. In

History of narrow wins

Year	< 100 votes	100 to 200 votes	200 to 500 votes	500 to 1000 votes
1967	1	3	4	9
1971	1	2	2	6
1977	2	3	8	11
1980	3	5	6	10
1984	-	1	-	2
1989	-	-	6	8
1991	-	-	-	1
1996	-	-	2	4
2001	2	1	1	5
2006	5	3	5	4
2011	-	-	4	4
2016	2	1	5	8
2021	-	1	2	5

The 2016 election broke a three-decade trend, as a ruling party retained power for the first time since 1980

Sathyamangalam, R. Rangasamy (AIADMK) won by 60 votes. N. Sivagnanam of Congress won in Thiruvonam by 62 votes.

No candidate was elected with a margin of less than 100 votes in the 1984 election held after the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. In the election fought by MGR from abroad, only three candidates won by a margin of less than 1,000 votes.

As many as 14 seats recorded margins between 200 and 1,000 votes in the 1989 election, held against the backdrop of a split in the AIADMK following MGR’s death. The DMK captured power after 13 years.

In the subsequent election in 1991, when Jayala-

lithaa rode to power on a sympathy wave following former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination, the only seat that witnessed a victory margin of below 1,000 was Harbour, where Karunanidhi defeated Subbu of Congress.

The 1996 election saw decisive mandates, thanks to an anti-corruption wave. Reflecting this, only six seats were won with margins of less than 1,000 votes, but none less than 200.

Political realignments

The 2001 election witnessed major political realignments. The AIADMK stitched together a broad alliance, including the Congress, and the Left parties, while the DMK aligned with the BJP. The AIADMK-led alliance secured a comfortable majority. In Nellikuppam, E. Pugazhendi (DMK) won by just 34 votes, while Parithi Ilangavazhuthi (DMK) scraped through by 86 votes.

The 2006 election was closely fought. This time,

the DMK allied with the Congress and the Left parties, and the AIADMK mainly with the MDMK. The DMK emerged as the single largest party and Karunanidhi formed the government with outside support. A total of 17 candidates won with margins below 1,000 votes. In Singanallur, R. Chinnasamy (AIADMK) defeated A. Soundararajan [CPI(M)] by just 14 votes. In Madurai East, N. Nanmaran [CPI (M)] defeated M. Boominathan (MDMK) by 51 votes. Interestingly, in Anicut, Pongalur, and Thottiam constituencies, the AIADMK, the DMK and Congress nominees respectively won by 53 votes each.

Eight Assembly seats recorded victory margins of less than 1,000 votes in 2011. The AIADMK formed a broad alliance that included the actor Vijayakant’s DMDK and the Left parties. It secured a sweep victory, with Jayalithaa returning as the Chief Minister and Vijayakant becoming the Leader of the Opposition.

The 2016 election broke a three-decade trend, as a ruling party retained power for the first time since 1980. As many as 16 candidates were elected with margins below 1,000 votes. In Radhapuram, DMK’s M. Appavu lost to AIADMK’s I.S. Inbadurai by 49 votes. In Kattumannarkoil, VCK leader Thol. Thirumavalavan was defeated by 87 votes.

The last election in 2021 witnessed eight candidates getting elected by margins of less than 1,000 votes.

Download your latest electronic Voter ID from the EC website

Dennis S. Jesudasan
CHENNAI

Are you preparing to vote in the April 23 Assembly election? Still waiting for your latest Voter ID, also known as EPIC? You don’t have to wait – you can now download your own e-EPIC.

If your name is on the electoral rolls and your mobile number is registered with the Election Commission (EC) and linked to your EPIC, you can download your e-EPIC from voters.eci.gov.in.

Once you open the portal, click the ‘e-EPIC Download’ option, and log in using your mobile number or EPIC number. After entering the captcha, you will receive an OTP on your registered phone number. Enter the OTP to verify and log in. You will then be prompted to enter your EPIC number again, along with the State where it is registered. Your name and Assembly constituency will appear on the screen.

Next, you must complete a second authentication using another OTP sent to your phone number. After verification, you can download your e-EPIC on your phone, tablet, or computer.

Officials say physical EPICs are being dispatched as quickly as possible. In the meantime, voters are encouraged to download their e-EPIC.

The e-EPIC contains details such as the elector’s name, the name of a relative (as provided during registration), gender, date of



Officials say physical EPICs are being dispatched as quickly as possible. FILE PHOTO

birth, address, and Assembly constituency.

It also includes the part number and the name and address of the polling station. Voters should note that the polling station details mentioned in the e-EPIC reflect the latest allocation. Since polling stations may change, electors are advised to verify their details in advance.

Is e-EPIC alone enough?

The e-EPIC states that it serves as proof of identity for election purposes, but merely possessing it does not guarantee that your name is on the rolls. Voters must check their names in the rolls before every election by visiting voters.eci.gov.in.

It also clarifies that the date of birth mentioned in the e-EPIC should not be used as proof of age for any purpose other than electoral registration.

The e-EPIC is valid across India as long as the voter is enrolled on the rolls. It also includes a secure QR code, which can be verified by election officials using an authorised application.

10-year-old boy run over by water tanker

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 10-year-old boy was killed after he was run over by a water tanker in Pallikaranai on Saturday. Tambaram police said Subramani, a resident of Vengaivasal and employed at a software company, was taking his son Ram on his two-wheeler to a school located on Palavaram-Thoraipakkam Radial Road. As Subramani was proceeding on Velachery

Main Road with his son, he hit another two-wheeler coming from the opposite direction, and he and his son fell. While he tried to get up, a water tanker coming from the back ran over his son, killing him on the spot. Pallikaranai traffic investigation police sent the boy's body to Tambaram Government hospital for a post-mortem, and arrested the lorry driver Ravichandran, a resident of Madipakkam.

Tambaram DMK MLA's supporters protest denial of poll ticket

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Incumbent Tambaram DMK MLA S.R. Raja, who has been denied a party ticket to contest the Assembly election this time from the constituency, thronged the residence of the party treasurer, T.R. Baalu, along with his supporters on Saturday night, and demanded that the

high command change the candidate for the constituency. They also visited Anna Arivalayam, the DMK's headquarters, on Sunday, and raised slogans against Minister T.M. Anbarasan, the candidate for Alandur constituency. Mr. Raja has represented the constituency three times. The party has fielded Krithika Devi in the con-

S.R. Raja's supporters alleged that they had not seen the new candidate for Tambaram, Krithika Devi, at party meetings

stituency this time. Mr. Baalu, after listening to their complaints, turned angry at one point and told

Selvakumar, one of Mr. Raja's supporters, "Don't create a scene by crying. Do you think I will believe you if you create a scene? I know who is loyal and who is merely creating a scene. I have known him (Mr. Raja) since he was a young man." Mr. Baalu said he had been visiting the party headquarters at 10 a.m. every day and returning

home at midnight. "I have raised the issue and received an appropriate response. He (Chief Minister M.K. Stalin) is more interested in Mr. Raja's welfare than I am. He is close to his family. I need not say anything because they know each other well. If he has not been announced as a candidate, there must be a reason, and I cannot reveal it in

front of everyone," he said. Mr. Baalu said he would again bring the issue to the notice of the Chief Minister, who might have taken the decision due to some extraordinary situation. "The media coverage itself will bring it to his notice," the senior DMK leader said. Mr. Raja's supporters alleged that they had not seen the new candidate at party meetings.

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Chennai Airport	36	26
Chennai City	34	26

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The morning will be pleasant. The day will be very warm. The night also will be pleasant. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. The day will be warm. The night will be pleasant.

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Timings
CHENNAI

MONDAY, MAR. 30			
RISE	06:07	SET	18:21
RISE	16:10	SET	04:06
TUESDAY, MAR. 31			
RISE	06:06	SET	18:21
RISE	17:00	SET	04:44
WEDNESDAY, APR. 01			
RISE	06:06	SET	18:21
RISE	17:49	SET	05:22

THE HINDU

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A CH-CHE

Flycatchers sighted at Pallikaranai marshland on their return journey

Winter migratory birds, including the rare Blue-throated Flycatcher, seen at Pallikaranai; birdwatcher says the sight of Flycatchers indicates the health of habitat



Chestnut-winged Cuckoo



Brown-breasted Flycatcher



Indian paradise Flycatcher

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

As migratory birds begin their return journey to northern breeding grounds, Flycatchers are once again being sighted at the Pallikaranai marshland, a wetland that continues to hold its ground amid growing urban pressures.

K.V.R.K. Thirunaranan of The Nature Trust, which has been documenting birdlife in Pallikaranai for the past 15 years with the support of the Forest Department, observed the presence of birds such as Asian brown Flycatcher, Indian paradise Flycatcher, Brown-breasted Flycatcher.

What surprised him the most, however, was the Blue-throated Flycatcher. “Blue-

throated Flycatchers are relatively rarer to spot,” he said.

While some species of flycatchers are native to or commonly found in the State, particularly in the Western Ghats region, ones such as Indian paradise flycatcher, Tickell’s blue Flycatcher, Asian brown Flycatcher, Brown-breasted Flycatcher, Blue-throated Flycatcher are winter migrants from northern and north-eastern India.

Migration patterns are not limited to long-distance movement along flyways. In Himalayan regions, several species also exhibit vertical migration, moving between lower and higher altitudes depending on seasonal conditions.

Return migration is as important as the arrival phase. “We begin to see early movements

in February and March, peak passage through March and April, and by May, most birds would have moved towards their breeding areas, including the Himalayan foothills,” he said.

A stopover site

India lies along the Central Asian Flyway, one of the major migratory routes connecting breeding grounds in Central Asia and beyond to wintering areas in South Asia. Wetlands such as Pallikaranai marshland function as stopover sites, providing food and resting grounds for birds undertaking long-distance travel.

“When birds keep coming back to the same site year after year, it shows that the habitat is still able to support them,” he said.

Three councillors of GCC to fight Assembly election

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Three Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) councillors have been nominated by the DMK to contest the Assembly election.

Councillors A. Raja Anbazhagan, of ward 141, N. Chitrarasu of ward 110 and A.P. Poornima, of ward 87, have been included in the list of candidates announced by the party on Saturday.

N. Chitrarasu who is contesting from Anna Nagar Assembly Con-

stituency is also the GCC Works Committee Chairman. A.P. Poornima will contest from Ambattur Assembly Constituency.

A. Raja Anbazhagan will contest from Thiyagarayanagar Assembly Constituency. He is the son of former DMK MLA J. Anbazhagan, who was elected from the same constituency in 2001. His AIADMK rival in the constituency, B. Sathyanarayanan, is also a former GCC Councillor who became an MLA in 2016. He lost by 137 votes to DMK’s J. Karunanidhi in the 2021 election.

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A CH-CHE



Heated campaign: Congress workers campaign in Bagalkot old city on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Lone struggle’ for BJP candidate in Bagalkot as leaders stay away

Rishikesh Bahadur Desai
BELAGAVI

As the bypoll fever rises along with the ambient temperature in Bagalkot, Karnataka, different stories seem to emerge from the camps of the BJP and the Congress. While a batch of senior Congress leaders are busy campaigning for Umesh Hullappa Meti, the party nominee, it seems that Veeranna Charantimath, the BJP candidate, is isolated and largely left to fend for himself.

The image of Mr. Charantimath as a short-tempered leader against Mr. Umesh Meti, who is seen as soft-spoken and approachable, seems to have focused the campaign on individuals rather than parties.

Mr. Charantimath's primary political opponent is his younger brother Mallikarjun Charantimath, a Congress leader. Mr. Mallikarjun Charantimath had fought the 2023 election as an Independent and gained over 10,000 votes. A few months later, Mr.

Mallikarjun Charantimath joined the Congress.

After the bypolls were announced, there were rumours on social media that he was planning to join the BJP. But he countered them.

“No BJP leader has met me till now. They do not have the moral courage to meet me. They are only making phone calls and inviting me to join the BJP. My question to them is regarding the time of their invitation,” he told reporters in Bagalkot recently. He was present when Mr. Umesh Meti filed his nominations and has been active in the Congress campaign.

Senior BJP leaders with local influence like Murugesu Nirani, former Minister, and Basavaraj Katageri, former chairman of the Bagalkot City Municipal Council, are yet to join Mr. Charantimath's campaign.

When reporters asked Mr. Charantimath about the absence of some leaders in his campaign, he said he would not invite anyone to support him.

Ruling LDF has backing of communal forces: UDF

Cong. leaders accuse Pinarayi Vijayan of orchestrating a vote deal with SDPI; row escalates after SDPI withdrew candidates in Vengara and Mankada; CM evades response on rejecting SDPI votes

Abdul Latheef Naha
MALAPPURAM

After years of accusing the United Democratic Front (UDF) of cosyng up to communal forces, the Communist Party Of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] now finds itself on the defensive, facing similar allegations from its long-time rival front. The UDF is accusing the party of forging an unholy nexus with the Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI), the political arm of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI).

Over the past six years, the CPI(M) had relentlessly criticised the UDF for receiving support from the Welfare Party of India (WPI), linked to the Jamaat-e-Islami Hind, branding the alliance as communal. Ironically, the Jamaat-e-Islami had backed the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala until 2019, and the CPI(M) had never labelled them communal during that period.

The political landscape shifted when the UDF began highlighting the alleged SDPI backing for the CPI(M).

Opposition's allegations
Leader of the Opposition V.D. Sathesnan and senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala directly accused Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan of orchestrating



The UDF is accusing CPI(M) of forging a vote deal with the Social Democratic Party of India. K.K. MUSTAFAH

ing a vote deal with the SDPI. Political heat increased after the SDPI withdrew candidates in Vengara and Mankada, where the LDF is supporting Independents against the UDF's K.M. Shaji and Manjalamkuzhi Ali, respectively. The move has emboldened UDF leaders to attack the CPI(M) on the communal front.

Evasive response

Persistent questions about the alleged SDPI support rattled the Chief Minister on Sunday. When asked, Mr. Vijayan told presspersons to approach the SDPI for clarification rather than him, and accused the media of pursuing a “special agenda”. He skirted direct answers on whether the CPI(M) would reject SDPI votes. Instead, he tried to

turn the spotlight back on the UDF for its alleged communal alliances.

At a press meet, Mr. Vijayan reiterated that the CPI(M) had never aligned with communal forces, maintaining a stance against both minority and majority communalism, both of which he described as dangerous for the State.

CPI(M) national general secretary M.A. Baby denied the UDF's allegations. However, like Mr. Vijayan, he refrained from committing that the LDF would reject SDPI votes. According to analysts, the cautious and evasive responses of the CPI(M) leaders reflect the party's current predicament, as the UDF skillfully weaponises the same communal narrative that the CPI(M) has used for years.

SFI petitions EC over MCC violation by IAS officer

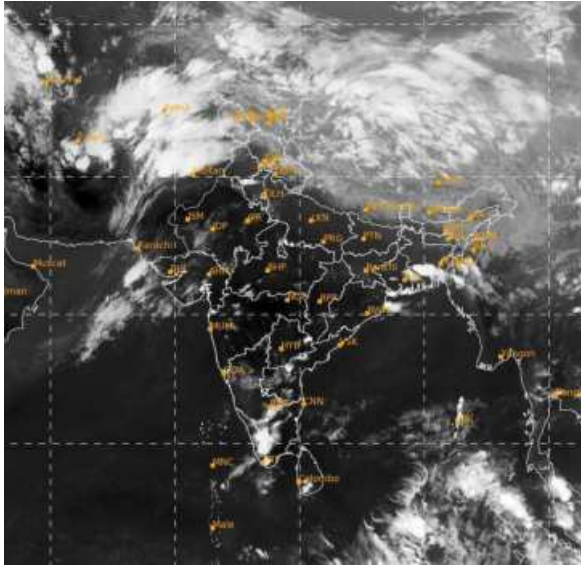
The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Students Federation of India has filed a complaint with the Chief Electoral Officer, Kerala, against senior IAS officer B. Ashok for alleged breach of the All India Services (Conduct) Rules, 1968, and the Model Code of Conduct.

The bureaucrat has been accused of attempting to influence voters and disparage the LDF government through a magazine article and during a prime-time television debate.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura. Thunderstorm accompanied with hailstorm likely at isolated places over East Rajasthan, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand and West Madhya Pradesh.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	0.3	32.6	20.5	Kozhikode	0.2	35.8	26.2
Ahmedabad	—	36.4	25.0	Kurnool	—	40.0	27.3
Aizawl	16.8	30.6	17.6	Lucknow	—	35.7	20.0
Allahabad	—	38.9	18.8	Madurai	—	39.0	25.6
Bengaluru	1.0	34.7	20.5	Mangaluru	31.0	33.8	22.4
Bhopal	—	36.6	22.2	Mumbai	—	33.4	24.7
Bhubaneswar	—	35.9	26.0	Mysuru	17.0	34.6	19.0
Chandigarh	2.0	27.3	19.2	New Delhi	—	35.7	20.9
Chennai	—	31.4	26.3	Patna	—	33.5	21.4
Coimbatore	—	37.8	22.5	Port Blair	—	32.4	24.7
Dehradun	—	27.4	18.8	Puducherry	—	32.6	24.0
Gangtok	13.0	17.5	10.2	Pune	—	35.4	24.7
Goa	—	34.3	24.4	Raipur	—	39.6	24.7
Guwahati	4.0	23.4	18.2	Ranchi	—	33.6	18.0
Hubballi	—	36.0	23.0	Shillong	6.0	18.2	10.4
Hyderabad	—	38.5	24.1	Shimla	1.0	15.8	9.8
Imphal	5.0	25.1	14.3	Srinagar	9.0	19.6	10.3
Jaipur	—	36.5	24.3	Thiruvananthapuram	—	37.8	25.0
Kochi	26.0	32.0	22.8	Tiruchir	—	37.9	25.4
Kohima	18.0	18.4	10.2	Vijayawada	—	37.8	26.0
Kolkata	—	33.4	24.7	Visakhapatnam	—	32.9	27.2

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	..5	..12	..23	20		—	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 260 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Kohima, Nagaland recorded a healthy AQI score of 21
Bengaluru	..3	..53	..22	91	124	—	
Chennai	..3	..12	—	36	63	—	
Delhi	..53	..45	103	..339	..229	—	
Hyderabad	..2	..7	..30	153	146	—	
Kolkata	..5	..16	..7	26	65	—	
Lucknow	..6	..46	..28	..199	..122	—	
Mumbai	..31	..12	..14	65	89	—	
Pune	..1	..25	..11	65	84	—	
Visakhapatnam	..42	..35	..17	49	120	—	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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A. Joseph Dorairaj

A bridge course is a preparatory one just before the start of a new academic year to help students transition smoothly from school to university. The twin objectives are to fill knowledge gaps and help students acclimatise themselves to a new environment.

For many students, bridge courses often revolve around transitions: to a higher knowledge ecosystem, to another medium of instruction (often from regional language to English), and from rural to urban or semi-urban settings. But, for all, the most crucial is the passage to young adulthood.

Problems

In many institutions, bridge courses do not yield the desired results. This is because some teachers, fuelled by the notion that they have to give the students a head start, try to package the curricula of the first semester into this time.

Another issue is that most adopt the same pedagogy of a regular class: the lecture method. Whereas an interactive method would be more suitable for the needs of these students.

Also, a bridge course classroom, is heterogeneous in nature. Teachers need to vary their teaching styles and strategies to cater to the differential abilities of the students.

Many institutions do not



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

From rote to the roots

Why bridge courses are important for students entering college

have a proper curriculum or textbooks for such courses. Even the schedule is tentative. So the faculty have to improvise and, often, do it badly.

Bridge courses are meant as much for academics as for socialisation and peer teaching and learning. However, the latter aspect is ignored. Bridge schools should not be confused with summer schools, which are rigorous and intensive pro-

grammes and are meant to boost students' domain knowledge.

Strategies

All these problems can be overcome by adopting certain efficient strategies. First, the faculty must understand that the objectives of a bridge course and a regular undergraduate programme are different and deploy appropriate pedagogies in the classroom. There should be less

teacher-talk and more student-talk, making the classroom student-centric and interactive.

Second, the focus must be on academics and social integration. To facilitate this, peer teaching and mentoring, especially by senior students, should be encouraged.

Third is the inclusion of fun-filled activities that will effectively help in social integration and, as Krashen argued, make learning

meaningful and faster when the affective filter is low.

Finally, a bridge course is a short-term programme. What could not be taught over 12 years of study in terms of domain knowledge and proficiency cannot be achieved in a couple of weeks. So, neither the student nor the faculty should expect miracles.

Bridge courses must focus on enhancing the participants' communication skills in English and deepen basic knowledge of the discipline's concepts to wean them away from rote memorisation and acquire knowledge in a systematic manner. This will provide a foundation for their undergraduate programme.

When conducted efficiently, bridge courses help students, especially those from disadvantaged backgrounds, to move to a different medium of instruction and also cope with the change to a college environment.

They are meant to acclimatise students to different intellectual and physical environments and fill knowledge gaps to some extent. In any rite of passage, the liminal space leading to aggregation is a crucial step and, therefore, bridge course participants should be helped to cross the threshold of liminality and enter the university.

The writer is an Emeritus Professor at Gandhigram Rural Institute Deemed-to-be University. Email: josephdorairaj@gmail.com

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BIG DREAMS NEED THE RIGHT START



Neighbours first

India must invite Nepal's new Prime Minister, Balen Shah, to revive ties

In an exchange of early messages, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Nepal's newly-sworn-in Prime Minister Balendra “Balen” Shah said they look forward to “working closely” to take forward bilateral ties. Delhi and Kathmandu are prepared to begin a new chapter in relations, united by familial bonds, a shared culture, open borders, and intertwined politics. Landlocked Nepal has depended on trade and transit through India, with India's plans for an energy grid in the region an important channel for Nepal's hydropower exports and revenues. Like many former leaders of Nepal, Mr. Shah studied in India. Familiarity aside, it would be a mistake to assume that his ascension will chart a well-worn and predictable course between the two countries. At 35, he is Nepal's first Madhesi leader, and upturns the old dominance of the Brahmin-Chhetri Pahadi elite. New Delhi must have a greater understanding of the priorities of this new Gen-Z movement that brought down the K.P. Sharma Oli government in 2025. This is a new leadership that has not inherited the old foreign policy understandings of the past generations of leaders that came through the panchayati movement, Congress and Communist parties, or the Maoist movement that overthrew the monarchy. In that sense, the Shah government's foreign policy, including its ties with China and the U.S., as well as the overarching relationship with India, is yet to be formalised. In the past decade, India has increased its development assistance to Nepal, but it also strained its ties over the constitution, the long blockade on border trade, and territorial issues. As Mayor of Kathmandu, Mr. Shah was known for his overt nationalism, and rejection of the “hegemony” of India and other powers, while his use of a map of “Greater Nepal” had been read with some concern in New Delhi.

The Modi government should tread lightly, and positively, as the Shah government finds its feet, but offer India's full support in dealing with Nepal's immediate challenges. Among those are the impacts of the war in West Asia where Nepal will need help with fuel and fertilizer imports. Approximately 14% of Nepal's population (about 3.5 million) work abroad, and the country is dependent on remittances and tourism revenues. New Delhi could also reconsider requests from previous Nepali governments to allow overflight for new Nepali airports, reduce restrictions on purchasing Nepali power produced with third-country assistance and to update the bilateral friendship treaty. Differences delayed New Delhi's invitation in 2024 to Mr. Oli, upon his election – he eventually visited Beijing first. It is time to quickly invite Mr. Shah to visit Delhi at the earliest, and for Delhi and Kathmandu to move forward, putting “Neighbours first” in South Asia.

On a wing

Subsidies will not create demand for air travel to small towns

In a bid to revive the regional aviation sector, the Union Cabinet has signed off on a 'Modified UDAN' scheme with a sixfold higher outlay. The scheme had first been launched to expand aviation to interior areas, using scheduled commuter airlines. Even then, industry analysts and experts had complained that UDAN did not make a viable business case for small regional airlines due to a lack of supporting infrastructure, low or unpredictable passenger demand, insufficient coverage of operating costs, and lack of awareness. In Modified UDAN, the subsidy period for tier-II and tier-III routes has been increased from three years to five years, an extension at least one of the small carriers had sought under UDAN before the COVID-19 pandemic hit. The exchequer will also fund the subsidies directly rather than having airlines levy an additional charge from passengers, with the government setting aside ₹10,043 crore over the next decade to this end. The government will also spend ₹12,159 crore to redevelop a hundred unused airstrips, ₹3,661 crore to build 200 helipads in remote areas, and purchase aircraft and helicopters for state carriers to boost last-mile connectivity to better match the mode of transport to actual demand and geography. The scheme will also pay for ongoing costs such as staffing and maintenance of low-traffic airports.

Regional aviation in India is structurally fragile and unlikely to become widely self-sustaining due to the unyieldingly high cost per passenger, price sensitivity, competition from rail and road transport, and operational inefficiencies. UDAN did not address them adequately and, sadly, Modified UDAN carries that failing over. The foremost one is weak underlying demand, with UDAN often picking routes with insufficient economic activity even as leisure and occasional travel could not sustain regular flights. Extending the subsidies, even if they are eased from the third year onwards, could keep routes alive for longer but will not of itself create demand. In this sense, the government's reluctance to revisit how it identifies and nurtures routes, and how different transport modes might substitute for air travel in low-density regions, seems inexplicable. The emphasis on last-mile connectivity and better planning also appears only partially incorporated as the details the Civil Aviation Ministry shared did not mention ground transport links or integrated scheduling, among others. Whether the decision to sustain connectivity using sustained government support, rather than cultivate a market that can stand on its own, will lead to lasting changes depends on whether route selection and integration with broader transport and economic networks improve in practice.

There has been a lively debate in the last few months about the respective merits of the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) and Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, or VB-G RAM G Act for short. Absent from this debate, however, is a critical issue that haunts both Acts: wage rates.

A key parameter

The wage rate is a critical parameter of employment guarantee. A relatively high wage rate can create a lot of enthusiasm among workers, as it happened in the early days of MGNREGA. And, enthusiasm is important for the success of the programme. Conversely, wage suppression can easily be used to restrain the programme or even phase it out over time. Wage rates, in any case, also have a strong influence on programme costs.

The wage rates of MGNREGA workers are determined under Section 6 of the Act. This section has two parts. The first part, Section 6(1), empowers the central government to notify MGNREGA wage rates. Different rates can be notified for different “areas”, and in practice, this has come to mean different States.

Section 6(2) states that until such time as the central government notifies wage rates under Section 6(1), State-specific minimum wages apply. More precisely, MGNREGA workers are entitled to the minimum wage notified by the State government for agricultural labourers.

MGNREGA came into force on February 2, 2006. Until 2009, the central government abstained from notifying wages under Section 6(1). Therefore, State-specific minimum wages applied. In many States, minimum wages for agricultural labourers were higher than market wages at that time. This is one reason why MGNREGA was so popular in those days.

In some States, there were significant increases in minimum wages between 2006 and 2009. The most notable instance was a sharp increase in the minimum wage in Uttar Pradesh in 2007-8 (when Ms. Mayawati was Chief Minister), from ₹58 to ₹100 per day. Some observers argued that State governments were indulging in unrestrained increases in minimum wages because MGNREGA wages were fully paid by the central government. Others countered that State governments had to pay the same wage on their own public works, and that this would be a restraining factor. They also argued that, except in Uttar Pradesh, there was little evidence of sharp increases in minimum wages.

The jury was still out on this when, in late 2009, the central government pressed the panic button and notified MGNREGA wage rates under Section 6(1). In the short term, this led to a further increase in wages, as the central



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The VB-G RAM G Act is a missed opportunity to correct serious anomalies in the determination of wage rates for MGNREGA workers

government notified ₹100 per day in most States, with a top-up in States where the minimum wage was above that norm. This was sold as a pro-worker move, in pursuance of a promise made by the Congress Party in the run-up to the 2009 general election. Over time, however, this move enabled the central government to moderate the growth of MGNREGA wages. In fact, the central government froze MGNREGA wages in real terms from then on. To this day, wages are raised State-wise every year to the extent of price increases (based on the Consumer Price Index for Agricultural Labourers), but not more.

Real-wage freeze consequences

This real-wage freeze rapidly led to two serious issues. First, MGNREGA wages started lagging behind minimum wages in many States, as minimum wages rose in real terms but MGNREGA wages did not. By 2025-26, the MGNREGA wage rate was lower – often much lower – than the minimum wage of agricultural labourers in most States, according to a recent analysis by Laavanya Tamang. This defeats an important purpose of MGNREGA: sustaining minimum wages. It also raises the question whether it is at all legal for the government to pay MGNREGA workers less than the minimum wage (this matter was taken up in the Supreme Court of India but was not clearly settled).

The other issue is that MGNREGA wages also started lagging behind market wages. Between 2009 and 2014, real wages were rising quite rapidly in rural India, partly because MGNREGA was tightening the labour market. By 2014, the ratio of MGNREGA wage rate to agricultural wage was around 60% for men and 75% for women at the all-India level, according to Labour Bureau data. The gap maintained itself from then on, as rural wage rates stagnated in real terms.

The real gap is actually much bigger than it looks. The reason is that market wages are not only higher than MGNREGA wages but also (generally) paid on time – often the same day. MGNREGA wages, by contrast, are often paid after long and uncertain delays. The central government keeps denying this, but the evidence is clear, notably from recent studies by the LibTech group. In fact, not only are there delays, sometimes, MGNREGA wages are not paid at all, for example due to technical failures of the Aadhaar-based Payment System or National Mobile Monitoring System. The result is a tremendous “discouragement effect” – many rural workers have lost interest in MGNREGA.

The absence of any marked decline in MGNREGA employment generation levels may seem to contradict this. A recent analysis of Periodic Labour Force Survey data, however, suggests that MGNREGA employment levels are in fact much lower today than they were in the early

years of all-India implementation, contrary to official statistics. The growing gap between official statistics and actual employment seems to reflect a major increase in leakages in the same period.

The discouragement effect and the resurgence of corruption are integrally related. When workers lose interest, there is no vigilance. Worse, workers may be tempted to cooperate with corrupt elements instead of working by the rules.

Continuing policy failure

Unfortunately, the VB-G RAM G Act is all set to perpetuate this crisis. For one thing, it does not contain any new, constructive provisions that might help to ensure the timely payment of wages or to curb corruption. For another, it continues to empower the central government to determine wage rates (under Section 10), even as the rationale for this has vanished.

Remember, the argument for an early switch from Section 6(2) to Section 6(1) under MGNREGA was that, when wages are fully paid by the central government, they should not be determined by the State government. Under the VB-G RAM G Act, however, wage costs are shared 60:40 between Centre and States. There was every reason to drop MGNREGA's Section 6(1) from the VB-G RAM G Act and revert to the principle of Section 6(2): guaranteed payment of minimum wages. Instead, the central government did the opposite: it dropped Section 6(2) and retained Section 6(1), giving itself perpetual powers to set the wage rates of VB-G RAM G workers.

There is another issue here. Section 6(1) of MGNREGA began with a non-obstante clause (“Notwithstanding anything contained in the Minimum Wages Act, 1948”) that acted as a kind of legal fig leaf for overriding minimum wages. Oddly, there is no equivalent of this clause in the VB-G RAM G Act. But then, how can the central government justify paying anything less than minimum wages?

A way forward would be for the central government to notify wage rates equal to or higher than minimum wages in all States (under MGNREGA or the VB-G RAM G Act, as the case may be). This would feed many birds with one crumb. It would put wage payments on a sound legal footing. It would lead to a much-needed increase in real wages. And, it would also produce a simple rule for updating wage rates over time.

More likely, the central government will prolong the real-wage freeze and use it as a means of ensuring that employment generation under the VB-G RAM G Act declines over time. If so, the wage freeze should be challenged in court. Indeed, with the non-obstante clause removed, the payment of anything less than minimum wages is patently illegal.

A Bill that secures IPS officers’ role in deputation

On March 25, 2026, the central government introduced the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026 in the Rajya Sabha to regulate the general rules governing the recruitment and conditions of service of ‘Group A General Duty Officers’ (GAGDO) and other officers in the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs). This Bill provides that 50% of Inspector General posts, a minimum of 67% of Additional Director General posts (ADG), and all Special Director General (SDG) and Director General posts shall be filled by deputation from the Indian Police Service.

Applies across CAPFs

By implication, deputation to the rank of the Deputy Inspector General and below, shall continue to be regulated by the prevailing rules. The Bill also saves any financial benefits granted to the GAGDO (Group A officer of the rank of Assistant Commandant and above) issued before. This Act shall apply to the five CAPFs – Central Reserve Police Force, Border Security Force, Central Industrial Security Force, Indo Tibetan Border Police and Sashastra Seema Bal. While the Bill aims to institutionalise the historical contributions and representation of the IPS in the CAPFs, it is seen by some as an instrument to undo the directions issued by the Supreme Court of India in *Sanjay Prakash and Others vs Union of India and Others* (May 2025).

The Court ruled mainly on two issues; to complete the pending cadre review and undertake the review of service rules in a given time-period; and to progressively reduce the number of posts earmarked for deputation in the CAPFs up to the level of Senior Administrative Grade (SAG) i.e., Inspector General rank, within a period of two years. It is thus clear that the recognition of the CAPFs as Organised Group ‘A’ Services (OGAS) was subject the provision of



R.K. Vij

A former Indian Police Service (IPS) officer

The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026 strengthens service rules and clarifies IPS deputation policy

deputation of IPS officers to various CAPFs.

The Court noted that there are various issues connected with the deployment of CAPFs, including coordination with the State Governments and the State police force. The appointment of IPS officers in each CAPF is vital to maintain the character of each CAPF. This is a policy decision manifest through the service rules of the CAPFs. The question of who shall head these forces was never contentious. It was not even a case that the petitioners’ service conditions had worsened since they joined the service.

A ‘unifying link’

Most of the senior operational posts in States are held by ADG or SDG rank officers. Therefore, the appointment of IPS officers to the CAPFs at senior ranks is essential for smooth relations with the State forces. Their selection process and training, along with field experience, give them a broader vision and an edge in leading forces whose main aim is to assist or work in tandem with State forces. Those who use the term ‘parachuting IPS officers into CAPFs’ seem unaware of Sardar Patel's vision, which envisaged the IPS as a unifying link between the Union and the States. The IPS officers have lived up to his dreams for decades, upholding the constitutional mandate.

The Ministry of Home Affairs, in January 2026, modified the empanelment guidelines of IPS officers at the Centre and made a minimum two-year stint at the Centre mandatory for empanelment at the rank of Inspector General. Therefore, the appointment of IPS officers in the Superintendent of Police (SP)/Deputy Inspector General of Police (DIG) ranks in the CAPFs will further cement their camaraderie with the cadre officers.

As far as reducing the posts of deputation is concerned, the Court seems to have ruled on the

policy matter which exclusively falls within the domain of the legislature and executive. While the Court clearly stated that the matter of taking IPS officers on deputation is a policy matter and the central government in its wisdom had taken a view that the presence of IPS officers in each CAPFs is vital, it erred in directing the central government to reduce the posts of deputation.

Judiciary’s role

The duty of the court is to interpret law. Courts may fill gaps in certain spheres, but they are not to plunge into policy making by adding something. The court is not expected to sit as an appellate authority on an option it feels wiser to. The Court has previously held that ‘the wisdom and advisability of the policies are ordinarily not amenable to judicial review unless the policies are contrary to statutory or constitutional provisions or arbitrary or irrational or an abuse of power’.

The Court, in *Gazula Dasaratha Rama Rao vs The State Of Andhra Pradesh & Others* (1960), held that ‘the service provisions under ... the Constitution do not enshrine any fundamental right of citizens; they relate to recruitment condition and tenure of service of persons, ... appointed to a Civil Service or to posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or any State’. Rightly so. The Court, in *Indian Ex Servicemen Movement and Ors. Vs. Union of India and Ors.*, held that it did not find any constitutional infirmity in the ‘One Rank One Pension’ principle.

The service conditions of CAPFs can be enhanced through regular intake and timely cadre reviews. The appointment of IPS officers on deputation to the CAPFs, being a policy matter beyond the scope of adjudication, is rightly being codified, leaving no room for divergent interpretations in the future.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Global silence continues

The President of the U.S. Donald Trump is speaking and acting not like a democratically elected leader of a democratic country, but like an autocratic leader of a medieval country talking about which country he is planning to conquer next (Inside pages, “Trump declares ‘Cuba is next’, denies losing MAGA support”, March 29). The

real tragedy of the times is that the rest of the world is almost silent. When Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro was captured by the U.S., ostensibly termed as a law enforcement operation “against an illegitimate leader” by the U.S., only a few countries have either condemned or expressed deep concern. And that was it. The reaction of world leaders has not been much

different in the ongoing Iran war. Now, Mr. Trump says “Cuba is next”, almost as if it is a football match or some such thing against another country's team. It is high time that the U.N. and sensible world leaders initiate some concrete and collective action to make Mr. Trump to realise that we are living in an era defined by an international order. **Kosaraju Chandramouli**, Hyderabad

American media report

If reports of U.S. business tycoon Elon Musk attending the private conversation between U.S. President Donald Trump and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi are true, it would constitute a serious breach of standard protocols governing such sensitive discussions (Inside Pages, “It was solely a conversation between Trump, Modi”, March 29).

Since the U.S. has not issued any rebuttal, the Union government needs to clarify what took place. **V. Johan Dhanakumar**, Chennai

A good beginning

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) won the IPL opener against Sunrisers Hyderabad in Bengaluru on Saturday in style. That it chased the target of 202 runs with six

wickets in hand and 26 balls to spare is a case in point. Virat Kohli and Devdutt Padikkal are the main reason for RCB registering a phenomenal win. Of course, RCB's bowlers did their bit well too. All said and done, RCB has started this IPL edition on a good note. **S. Ramakrishnasayee**, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

How to secure India’s supply chains

India’s manufacturing ecosystem is deeply embedded in global supply chains. From energy and fertilizers to electronics and chemicals, several sectors rely heavily on imported raw materials and intermediates. The recent geopolitical development in West Asia has shown how quickly supply disruptions can ripple through the economy, underscoring a stark reality that while global interdependence is beneficial, it also amplifies vulnerability. As the country navigates ongoing supply chain disruptions, the events have reinforced the need for building long-term resilience through reduced import dependence.

Ensuring flow of energy
Energy is the backbone of any economy, powering manufacturing, transport, agriculture and services. India imports about 85% of its crude oil and over 50% of its gas, making it highly vulnerable to geopolitical shocks. Price spikes transmit quickly across sectors, raising input costs across manufacturing; increasing logistics expenses; and even pushing up consumer prices via diesel and fertilizer linkages. It is estimated that every \$10 per barrel hike in crude prices can cause a \$13-\$14 billion rise in the import bill, 30-40 bps rise in consumer inflation (with complete pass through), and could even lower Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth by 0.2-0.3 percentage points. Long-term energy security is, therefore, critical and must be anchored in diversification, domestic capacity, and technological transition.

Accelerating renewable energy is central to reducing import dependence on oil. India’s progress towards the target of 500 GW of non-fossil capacity by 2030 is noteworthy. However, resilience requires significant investments in RE storage to manage intermittency. The National Green Hydrogen Mission offers a pathway to decarbonise industries



Anant Goenka
President of the FICCI

Supply chain resilience cannot be built through isolated interventions. It requires an integrated, forward-looking approach

reliant on imported oil and gas. Even as the country steps up renewable energy adoption, expanding domestic oil and gas exploration is necessary to ensure long-term energy resilience. Strengthening buffers by expanding strategic petroleum reserves can help the country withstand short-term supply disruptions. India has already started to diversify oil import sources, which is a positive step.

Securing food security
Even as India has emerged as a net exporter of several agri-commodities such as cereals and marine products, some of the most critical segments of the food value chain are deeply import-dependent. India’s high import dependence on edible oils, pulses and fertilizers is a key concern as any supply disruption can have direct consequences on inflation and rural livelihoods.

Pulses and oilseeds need assured procurement, price support, and region-specific crop diversification. Scaling and accelerating the existing missions on oilseeds can reduce the current import gap, where domestic output meets barely 44% of demand. The government must also work towards buffering and holding strategic reserves for edible oils and pulses to meet any contingency requirements. Fertilizer sector reforms must focus on the diversification of suppliers mix, enhancing the domestic production of phosphatic and potassic fertilizers, and the introduction of alternative bio-fertilizers that can be adopted at scale.

Supply chain risks in manufacturing (raw materials and intermediates) can also have a deep impact. India’s imports account for nearly 19% of GDP. Of this, raw materials make up 34%, intermediates 31%, and capital goods 24%. Consumer goods account for just 12%. India dominates downstream manufacturing but is exposed to imports in upstream and

midstream inputs such as APIs, electronics, and industrial intermediates, amongst others.

The need for diversification
On the raw material front, copper, lithium, cobalt and other rare earth minerals remain globally concentrated, making India vulnerable given their centrality to electronics, electric mobility, and advanced manufacturing. On intermediates, India imports nearly 65-70% of its pharmaceutical intermediates from China despite being a global leader in generic drug exports. Likewise, with respect to electronic imports, India has a high dependence on semiconductors, display units, and components from East Asia. Limited domestic capability in high-end industrial machinery constrains India’s manufacturing competitiveness and reinforces reliance on external ecosystems. These are not easily substitutable inputs. When they are disrupted, production stops.

The first and most critical priority is thus deepening domestic manufacturing in intermediates. While current policy frameworks have largely incentivised final assembly, the next phase must target overall domestic ecosystems such as strengthening the manufacturing of APIs, and semiconductors. Diversification must also continue, with long-term supply agreements and strategic partnerships across regions, including in the markets of Africa and Latin America. Re-engineering of industrial processes can also help reduce import intensity. Encouraging industry to adopt direct conversion technologies, alternative materials, and input-efficient production methods will gradually lower structural vulnerability.

Supply chain resilience cannot be built through isolated interventions. It requires an integrated, forward-looking approach involving government, industry, and global partners.

A sidetracked railway in Visakhapatnam

The delay in the functioning of a Railway zone has led to anxieties flaring up

STATE OF PLAY

B. Madhu Gopal
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The Visakhapatnam-headquartered DBK Railway executed three prestigious Railway line projects without any time or cost overruns over 50 years ago. Now, even after seven years since Visakhapatnam was chosen as the headquarters of the new South Coast Railway (SCoR) zone, there has hardly been any progress on the ground.

The failure of the Railway Board to issue a Gazette notification on the SCoR so far has created doubts in the minds of the public about the Centre’s intentions. Though Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has stated that the new zone would start “soon,” he has remained silent on the issue of the Gazette notification, which is crucial for the zone to start functioning.

The Narendra Modi-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government had announced the creation of the SCoR, with its zonal headquarters in Visakhapatnam, ahead of the general elections in February 2019. After the elections, there were hardly any steps taken to get the ball rolling. An Officer on Special Duty was appointed and a Detailed Project Report submitted, but concrete decisions have been inordinately delayed. Though Mr. Modi had visited Visakhapatnam on a couple of occasions between 2019 and 2024, and had the foundation stone laying ceremony included in his schedule in one of these visits, it was withdrawn at the eleventh hour. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders had then claimed that the operationalisation of the SCoR would be



nefit the YSR Congress Party without giving any advantage to them. But now the Telugu Desam Party (TDP)-Jana Sena Party (JSP)-BJP alliance government is in power; and apart from laying the foundation stone last year, progress on the Railway zone has been slow. What is stopping the ‘double-engine sarkar’ from hastening work on the zone?

Off the rails
Interestingly, on the other hand, some BJP leaders, including Union Minister Kishan Reddy from Telangana, have expressed concerns over the injustice done to Visakhapatnam and the north Andhra region by the Bhubaneswar-headquartered East Coast Railway (ECoR) over the last two decades. While this includes the delay in extending highly patronised trains terminating at Visakhapatnam junction to Bhubaneswar, and the failure to start new trains originating from Visakhapatnam, it also has to deal with an issue involving the Waltair division.

At the time of the creation of the ECOR, in 2003, a large portion of the Waltair division (originating in Andhra) was given away to create the Sambalpur division in Odisha, while the remaining part was merged with the ECOR. At present the Waltair division, under the ECOR, extends over a length of 1,106.44 km, covering three States – mainly Andhra, Odisha and Chhattisgarh. Even then, as the SCoR was

being created with headquarters in Visakhapatnam, Odisha staked claim over the entire Kottavalasa-Kirandul (K-K) line, which is the lifeline of the Waltair division. This is in contrast to the earlier proposal to bifurcate the K-K line.

Andhra Pradesh BJP president P.V.N. Madhav, when he was BJP MLC, had written to the then Railway Minister stating that the revenue from the Waltair Division was more than the combined revenues of Vijayawada, Guntur, and Guntakal divisions put together. He had noted: “We are willing to part with the Odisha portion of the K-K line between Koraput-Kirandul, Kunderu-Theruvai, and Koraput-Rayagada, as they belong to Odisha. But how can the backward regions of Uttarandhra [region in northern Andhra] be transferred to Rayagada Division?” However, the BJP-led NDA government is now in favour of transferring the entire K-K line to the Rayagada division in Odisha to further its political interests in that State.

Delayed progress
The lack of a gazette notification has effectively meant no work happening across any fronts. At a meeting about a decade ago, top officials of the DBK Railway Project recalled that all three major line expansion projects were completed on time because DBK Railway had full powers to take decisions, preventing procedural delays in obtaining sanctions. Now, though a General Manager has been appointed for the SCoR, Railway sources say that without the issuance of the Gazette notification, he has no powers to take major decisions. It is high time that Visakhapatnam – the growth engine of Andhra Pradesh – is given a better deal by the ‘double-engine sarkar’.

The rise of temporary teachers in West Bengal

The State has not been able to expand its institutional capacity in line with rising demand

DATA POINT

Arnab Chakrabarti
Anwesha Basu

West Bengal’s higher education system is increasingly being defined by an unusual feature: an exceptionally high reliance on temporary teachers. While contractual and ad-hoc faculty are not uncommon across Indian universities, the scale observed in West Bengal is far beyond the national norm. Evidence from the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) reveals that this is not a short-term administrative adjustment, but a persistent structural feature of the system.

Chart 1 captures the magnitude of the issue. Over the past decade, the share of temporary teachers in West Bengal has consistently remained above 15%, far exceeding that of any other major State. In 2021-22, while Rajasthan (1.25%), Tamil Nadu (2.84%), and even Uttar Pradesh (6%) reported relatively modest shares, West Bengal stood at a striking 18%. In absolute terms too, the State leads, with over 13,200 temporary teachers – higher than Karnataka (11,300), which ranks second. The skew is even sharper along gender lines. Temporary appointments account for 22.5% of all female teachers in the State, compared to 15.4% for men. The next highest share of female temporary teachers among major States is just 7.8%.

While the latest data from AISHE are available only up to 2021-22, the insights they reveal are still relevant. Structural features of higher education systems such as institutional capacity, hiring practices, and workforce composition tend to evolve slowly. As such, the trends observed are unlikely to have reversed dramatically in the short span since, and continue to offer valuable insights.

A common explanation for the unusually high share of temporary

teachers in West Bengal could be that such reliance stems from a freeze in permanent recruitment. However, data does not support this claim. Growth in permanent teaching positions in West Bengal has fluctuated between 8% and 15% annually – neither stagnant nor unusually low relative to other States (**Chart 2**). Moreover, we see that the growth of temporary and permanent teachers in West Bengal has broadly moved in tandem.

An alternative line of inquiry is whether this pattern reflects a demand-side pressure, specifically whether a higher Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in West Bengal has outpaced the system’s ability to expand permanent faculty. However, a comparison of GER across States suggests otherwise. West Bengal’s GER (26.3% in 2021-22) is not particularly high; in fact, it lies toward the lower end of the spectrum, with States like Tamil Nadu (47%), and even Rajasthan (28.6%) outperforming by a margin.

The problem, therefore, lies elsewhere – on the supply side of higher education.

Strained numbers
West Bengal has not been able to expand its institutional capacity in line with rising demand. Between 2017-18 and 2020-21, the number of institutions grew by just 10.83%, well below other States with relatively weaker educational infrastructure, such as Rajasthan (23.5%), Madhya Pradesh (21%), and Uttar Pradesh (19%). This limited expansion has resulted in a heavy burden on existing institutions. With roughly 1,100 students per institute, West Bengal ranks second in the country, behind Delhi, and far above most other States.

This strain is further reflected in teaching capacity. The pupil-teacher ratio in the State ranges between 29 and 35 – among the poorest in India (**Chart 3**). Compared to many other major States, the number of permanent faculty per one lakh students is also low in West Bengal (257). These indica-

tors converge on a single conclusion: there are simply not enough institutions or permanent teachers to meet the demand for higher education.

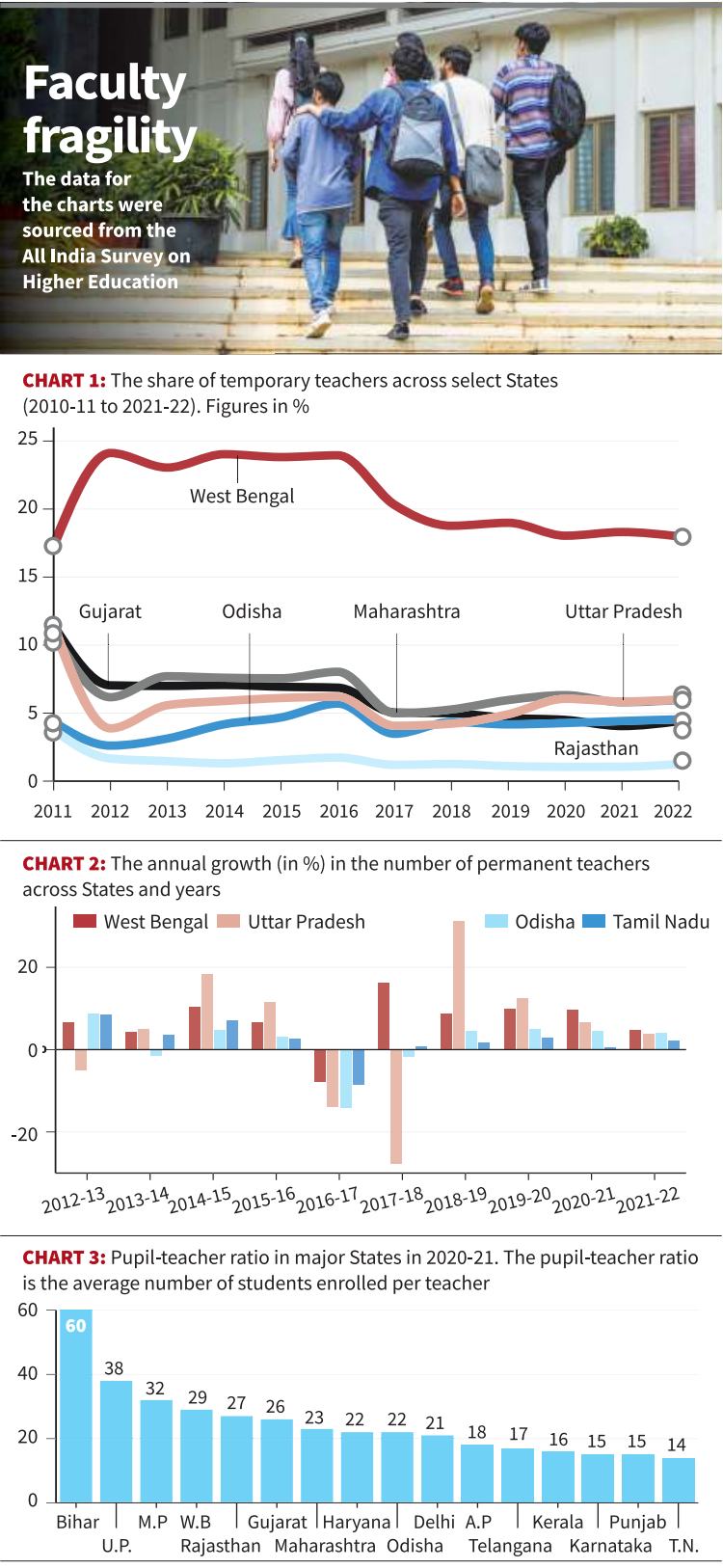
In this context, the proliferation of temporary teachers appears less a policy choice and more a coping mechanism. An excessive reliance on temporary teachers may have a fiscal incentive from the State’s perspective in the short run, but it has certain long-term consequences on the health of the higher education system. By design, such positions offer limited job security, lower pay, and little scope for research or professional development. This can adversely affect teaching quality, as instructors juggling multiple appointments may have less time and lower incentive for student engagement or curriculum development. A system that depends heavily on precarious employment risks disincorporating individuals from pursuing academic careers altogether. Moreover, since temporary positions are disproportionately filled by women and early-career academics, existing inequities are deepened.

The implications of this structural imbalance extend beyond the higher education system itself. In recent years, the policy focus of the West Bengal government has increasingly leaned towards cash transfer schemes aimed at immediate welfare gains.

While such interventions help vulnerable households, they cannot be a substitute for long-term investments in human capital.

Addressing the underlying structural constraints – expanding institutional capacity, improving student-teacher ratios, and strengthening the base of permanent faculty – is essential. Without these reforms, the State risks undermining its ability to generate a skilled and productive workforce.

The authors are Assistant Professors, FLAME University. With inputs from Ridhima Mittal, UG2 student, FLAME University.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 30, 1976

Space dept. posts out of UPSC purview

New Delhi, March 29: Though the Union Public Service Commission is not in favour of excluding from its purview technical and administrative posts, it has finally made an exception in the case of the Department of Space and the Space Commission in “national interest”.

The Commission’s view had been that certain Ministries and departments had the tendency to seek exemption from the requirements of Article 320 (3) of the Constitution in regard to large categories of posts under them. Several proposals for the exclusion of posts, mainly scientific and technical, had been referred to it, and the Commission had advised against them. It considered that proposals of this nature raised fundamental issues of national importance, the precise impact of which on the role and functions of the Commission, on the standard and quality of public services and on the morale of officers manning these services needed to be clearly understood. As an instance, it has pointed out that the Government had referred to it for reconsideration the proposal for exclusion of technical and administrative posts in the Department of Space and Space Commission from the Commission’s purview. While appreciating the fact that the work in the Department and Space Commission was of a highly technical nature, the UPSC said that it had already explained that special arrangements had been made for obtaining the best technical advice for making selections to these posts.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 30, 1926

Calcutta commercial institute

Calcutta, March 29: Presiding over the prize distribution ceremony at the Government Commercial Institute, this afternoon, the Hon’ble Mr. J.W.A Bell, President, Bengal Chamber of Commerce, said that in a conservative country, like India, it was always difficult for a comparatively new institution to find its way into public confidence. This Institute filled a want in the educational system of India; but it was desirable in a great industrial country, which India was becoming, that there should be an institution in which education was imparted, along strictly commercial and industrial lines.

From Page One

Iran warns against ground invasion

Egypt's Badr Abdelatty, who was part of the talks with Turkiye's Hakan Fidan, Saudi Arabia's Prince Faisal Bin Farhan, and Pakistan's Ishaq Dar, said the meetings were aimed at opening a "direct dialogue" between the U.S. and Iran.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps warned in a statement that it would consider Israeli universities and branches of U.S. universities in the region "legitimate targets" unless offered safety assurances for Iranian universities, state media reported after Israeli strikes hit several universities, including ones claimed to have been used by the Islamic Republic for nuclear research and development.

Israel announced waves of incoming strikes from Iran on Sunday and explosions could be heard throughout Tehran.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif earlier said he and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian had held "extensive discussions" on the regional hostilities. Officials said 20 more Pakistani-flagged ships were allowed to transit the Strait of Hormuz late on Saturday as Iran eased restrictions over the critical waterway.

IRGC also said that they launched strikes on aluminium plants in Bahrain and the UAE over the weekend, targeting what they described as industries linked to the U.S. military. It added that the strikes were retaliation for a U.S.-Israeli attack on Iranian industrial infrastructure launched from bases in Gulf states. Aluminium Bahrain, one of the world's largest aluminium producers, said two employees were wounded in the strike.

(With AFP inputs)

BJP is the 'A team' of Kerala, says PM Modi

The Prime Minister said that for decades, Kerala had been trapped between the fronts that alternated in power without delivering progress. "If one was communal, the other was overly communal; if one was corrupt, the other was excessively corrupt. Both UDF and LDF have cheated the public by relying on vote-bank politics," he said.

The Prime Minister accused the LDF government of plunging Kerala into a debt of ₹5 lakh crore. "Kerala's debt has tripled in the last 10 years, with the money going into the pockets of the LDF," he said. If the NDA comes to power, we will recover the funds and use them for the welfare of the public, Mr. Modi said.

He said both the Congress and the Left shared a long history of misgovernance, pointing to the Left's record in Bengal and Tripura and the Congress's performance nationwide. He stressed the BJP's focus on a women-led development model, highlighting initiatives across several sectors, including health, and citing the passage of the Nari Shakti Vandana Adhiniyam law. "Under the NDA, girls from disadvantaged backgrounds will be empowered to achieve new heights," he said, contrasting this with Congress leaders, whom he described as obstacles to women's progress.

Acknowledging the hard work of Palakkad's paddy farmers, Mr. Modi said that only the BJP can provide effective support to the farming community. "Instead of helping, the State government is trapping farmers in debt," he said, adding that an NDA government in Kerala would end their woes, a promise he called "Modi's guarantee".

He promised to expose the corruption involving the LDF and the UDF if the BJP comes to power in Kerala. "Both of them are engaged in corruption and looting, but they never expose each other. The BJP will ensure justice for the people by investigating and revealing the LDF-UDF misdeeds," he said.

'I am the candidate in all the seats', says Mamata

This was the first time during the 2026 election campaign that Ms. Banerjee was projecting herself as candidate in all the 294 Assembly seats. Almost 10 years ago, ahead of the 2016 Assembly polls, when several Trinamool leaders, including Ministers, were caught on camera accepting cash for party funds in the Narada sting videos, the Chief Minister on whom the campaign of the party is centred, had made similar remarks that she was the candidate in all seats.

The 2021 Assembly polls in West Bengal, where the Trinamool Congress was successfully able to resist the attack by the Bharatiya Janata Party, was built on the campaign "*Banglar Nijer Mein Ki Chai* [Bengal wants its own daughter]."

The Trinamool Congress has fielded candidates in 291 out of the 294 seats and left the three seats to its ally, Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha. Ms. Banerjee is contesting from Bhabanipur.

During her speech at Manbazar in Purulia, Ms. Banerjee retorted to the remarks made by Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday where he had said that the Chief Minister always played the 'victim card'. "Sometimes she talks about her injury; sometimes she abuses the Election Commission. But the people of West Bengal now understand her victim card politics very well," he had said.

The Chief Minister said she had repeatedly returned from the brink of death and wondered if the BJP leaders want her dead. "I have repeatedly returned from the brink of death. Go and check the report of the doctor... Did you deliberately injure my leg during the 2021 elections? Are you planning to kill me?" Ms. Banerjee said.

Challenging times, says PM on West Asia crisis

Modi warns against politicising the issue, says the region is a major centre of India's energy needs, and due to the ongoing war, a 'crisis' regarding petrol and diesel is emerging around the world

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday noted that the situation in West Asia had created "challenging times" and called for those "politicising" the issue to refrain from doing so. He cautioned Indians against believing rumours related to the crisis.

Speaking during his monthly *Mann Ki Baat* address, the Prime Minister said that following the COVID-19 pandemic, it was expected that the world would move forward on a path of renewed progress.

"However, situations of war and conflict have continuously kept arising in different parts of the world," he said.

"At present, a fierce war has been going on in our neighbourhood for a month. Millions of our family members, near and dear ones, live in these countries, especially working in the Gulf countries."

Deeply grateful

"I am deeply grateful to the Gulf countries for providing all kinds of assistance to more than one crore Indians there," he added.

Mr. Modi noted that the



I would once again urge all my countrymen that we must unitedly overcome this challenge. Those who are politicising even this issue should refrain from doing so. This is a matter concerning the interests of 140 crore countrymen; there is no place for self-serving politics.



NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister

West Asian region is a major centre of India's energy needs, and due to the ongoing war, a "crisis" regarding petrol and diesel is emerging around the world.

"These certainly are challenging times," he said. "I would once again urge all my countrymen that we must unitedly overcome this challenge. Those who are politicising even this issue should refrain from doing so. This is a matter concerning the interests of 140 crore countrymen; there is no place for self-serving politics."

"Therefore, those who are spreading rumours are causing a major harm to the country," Mr. Modi added. "I would also appeal to all citizens to remain vigilant and not be misled by rumours. Trust only the

continuous information provided by the government and take action based only on that."

Key initiatives

During his address, the Prime Minister also took note of various initiatives aimed at nation-building. One such initiative was the Gyan Bharatam Survey aimed at collecting information about manuscripts across the country.

"If you have a manuscript or information about it, do share its image on the Gyan Bharatam App," Mr. Modi said, adding, "Information related to each entry is being verified before it is recorded. I am glad that thousands of manuscripts have been shared so far."

Another initiative he highlighted was MY Bharat

Budget Quest. "It aims to connect the youth across the country with the Budget process and policymaking," the Prime Minister said. "Nearly 12 lakh youth from across the country participated in the quiz."

Sports achievements

The Prime Minister also devoted a section of his address to India's sporting achievements in the recent past.

"When India achieved a historic victory in the T20 World Cup, a wave of joy swept across the country," he said. "We are all very proud of our team's thumping success."

"Late last month, a thrilling match was witnessed in Hubli, Karnataka. By winning this match, the Jammu and Kashmir cricket team secured for themselves the Ranji Trophy," he said. He remarked that this success for Jammu and Kashmir will encourage many young people to take up sports, adding that the people of J&K have a "tremendous passion" for sports. "I am glad that it is now becoming a hub for major sporting events," Mr. Modi said. "I hope this winning streak of J&K sports persons continues in the future."

'Global acceptance of Pakistan a failure of Indian foreign policy'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Jairam Ramesh

In the context of Pakistan mediating between the United States and Iran to resolve the ongoing conflict in West Asia, Jairam Ramesh, general secretary (communications) of the Congress, on Sunday criticised the Bharatiya Janata Party-led government's foreign policy, alleging that Pakistan's renewed global acceptance reflected failures in India's diplomatic engagement and narrative management.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh described Pakistan as a country where "democracy is a farce," its economy "a basket case dependent on the IMF, China, and Saudi Arabia," and one regarded as "a haven for terrorists" whose activities have targeted countries across the world.

Mr. Ramesh argued that despite Pakistan's isolation after the 2008 Mumbai attacks, it had recently regained international acceptance. Citing External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's description of Pakistan as a "*dadal*", he said this shift underscored what he termed the "colossal failure" of the Modi government's foreign policy.

He added that U.S. President Donald Trump, whom Prime Minister Na-

rendra Modi has publicly called a "good friend", had also contributed to Pakistan's current standing. Mr. Ramesh questioned why the Prime Minister, despite showcasing close ties with Washington at events such as the *Howdy Modi* rally in Houston in 2019 and the Namaste Trump event in Ahmedabad in 2020, had "allowed this to happen".

Mr. Ramesh alleged that the government's attempts to curry favour with the U.S., including what he called a "betrayal of India's farmers" through a trade deal granting American agricultural interests unprecedented market access, had yielded no diplomatic leverage.

Mr. Ramesh said the "unravelling" of what he described as a "heavily personality driven foreign policy" had exposed the "*Vishwaguru*" persona as a "Vishwaphoney".

Maoist killed in Sukma encounter, say police

The Hindu Bureau
RAIPUR

A Maoist carrying a reward of ₹5 lakh has been killed in an ongoing encounter with the security forces in Sukma district of Chhattisgarh, the police said on Sunday.

Sukma Superintendent of Police Kiran Chavan said that on the basis of intelligence about the presence of Maoists in the hills in the Polampalli police station limits, a team of personnel from the Sukma District Reserve Guard (DRG) started a search operation.

During the operation, intermittent firing took place between the DRG team and the Maoists on Sunday morning, said Mr. Chavan, adding that on searching the encounter site, the body of one male Maoist was recovered.

The Maoist was later identified as Muchaki Kailash, who was wanted for civilian killings, attacks, and conspiracy to carry out IED blasts and was carrying a reward of ₹5 lakh, said Mr. Chavan.

Anti-Maoist campaign saw continuity across regimes, says former official

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Both Congress-led and BJP-led governments at the Centre pursued a broadly consistent approach in handling the Maoist problem in the country, said K. Vijay Kumar, former senior security adviser to the Union Home Ministry, who worked with administrations of both parties.

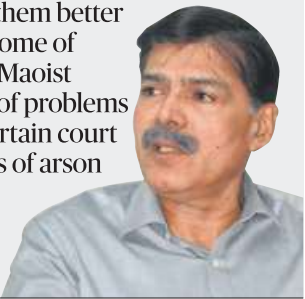
He said that the years 2006 to 2009 were the most difficult and the gains made over the years found a resolute push in the past two years when Home Minister Amit Shah set a deadline of March 31, 2026, to eradicate left-wing extremism from the country.

Mr. Kumar, who is a retired 1975-batch Indian Police Service (IPS) officer and former Director-General of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), said in an interview with *The Hindu* that former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had rightly recognised Maoism as the foremost internal security threat.

After the 2010 killing of 76 security personnel in



Both of us played a direct role in facilitating the training of 3,000-4,000 special forces personnel. It was done in a discreet way, giving them better arms and training. And some of them were surrendered Maoist cadres. There were a lot of problems earlier, stigmatised by certain court observations...allegations of arson and looting



K. VIJAY KUMAR
Former security adviser to the Ministry of Home Affairs

Chhattisgarh, former Home Minister P. Chidambaram pushed through centrally assisted funding for counter-Maoist operations, Mr. Kumar, who resigned from the Home Ministry in 2022, said. Around 200 district collectors were given discretionary funds to fortify police stations and improve mobility in remote areas, he said. "In Bijapur, the collector procured 30 to 40 vehicles to address the lack of transport, which were never ambushed as they directly benefited local communities," he said.

He said in 2014-15, under National Security Ad-

viser Ajit Doval, a push was given to train local tribal youth in Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. "Both of us played a direct role in facilitating the training of 3,000-4,000 special forces personnel. It was done in a discreet way, giving them better arms and training. And some of them were surrendered Maoist cadres. There were a lot of problems earlier, stigmatised by certain court observations... allegations of arson and looting," Mr. Kumar said.

He said that 99.99% of allegations of human rights violation against security forces were false and part

of "psy ops" to demoralise the armed personnel.

He said after the Dantewada incident, the CRPF was made the "patch force" which could operate across States and beyond police jurisdictions, and in 2011, it got a separate intelligence wing. "Cash was disbursed through helicopters. There was no sign of governance in many places. CRPF camps acted as the single point of the government," he said.

He added that the "children wing" of the Maoists were the most ruthless. "The child cadres are good in observation, and they can be heartless. Similarly, the woman cadres were better trained than the men," the former CRPF Director-General said.

As operations expanded steadily, he said, training, equipment, integration, and coordination improved year after year. "That is the only difference I see – greater vigour over time – but the continuity in approach remained," he said, adding that he himself was part of that continuity across governments.

JD(U) leaders meet Nitish as time closes in on resignation

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

With just a day left for Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar to resign from the Legislative Council, senior leaders of his Janata Dal (United) party rushed to his official residence in Patna to hold closed-door meetings, amid pleas from a section of the party for Mr. Kumar to remain in Bihar, and a lack of clarity regarding his successor.

Mr. Kumar secured a Rajya Sabha seat through an election held on March 16. He is required to resign from his seat in the State legislature – and step down from the Chief Minister's post – within 14 days of being elected to Parliament.

Bihar Assembly Speaker Prem Kumar had noted that Mr. Kumar had time to resign till March 30.

The leaders who met with Mr. Kumar at his official residence on Sunday included Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, State Minister Vijay Kumar Choudhary, State Minister Ashok Choudhary, JD(U) working president Sanjay Jha, and several MLAs.

Sources said that during the meeting, several leaders suggested that Mr. Kumar should not leave Bihar politics. However, after the meeting, Mokama MLA Anant Singh said though he had also urged him to stay back, Mr. Kumar had made his decision, and was likely to resign on March 30. "I urged him not to resign but he did not listen to me," Mr. Singh said.

Race for CM's post

In the race to succeed Mr. Kumar, the front runner is BJP leader and Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary.

However, several JD(U) leaders have said that Mr. Nitish Kumar's son, Nishant Kumar, who recently entered active politics, should take over the post.

ASSEMBLY POLLS

Fast justice for Zubeen among 5 Cong. guarantees

Fast justice for Zubeen Garg, the late cultural icon, was among five guarantees the Congress rolled out for poll-bound Assam on Sunday.

Addressing an election rally at Nowboicha in Assam's Lakhimpur district, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge promised justice for Garg within 100 days if voted to

power. "We will find out who murdered him and present the findings in the specified time," he said, insisting the Congress guarantees were unconditional, unlike BJP's.

Mr. Kharge said Congress would provide ₹50,000 to women to start or grow businesses, apart from monthly cash transfers, and ₹1,250 as a pension to senior citizens. The other guarantees are ₹25 lakh cashless health cover for every family and land rights for 10 lakh indigenous people.



Mallikarjun Kharge addressing an election rally at Nowboicha in Lakhimpur district. PTI

'BJP, AJUP are seeking votes in religion's name'

Senior Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee on Sunday accused the BJP and Humayun Kabir's Aam Janata Unnayan Party of seeking votes in the name of religion while ignoring basic issues such as livelihood and food.

Addressing a rally in support of the Trinamool candidate in the Naoda

Assembly constituency in Murshidabad, the party national general secretary alleged that while the BJP was doing "temple politics", Mr. Kabir was indulging in "masjid politics", neglecting issues such as development and employment.

"In Murshidabad, while BJP is conspiring to foment riots during Ram Navami processions, Kabir is misleading people in the name of laying the foundation stone of mosque named after Babri Masjid," he said. PTI



We do not form governments for infiltrators. Only the people of Assam and the country have rights here. We will protect mothers and sisters of Assam

NITIN NABIN
BJP chief

EC suspends 3 CAPF personnel over viral video

The Election Commission suspended three Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) personnel after a video went viral showing them playing carrom inside a Trinamool Congress office at Suri in West Bengal's Birbhum, a senior official said on Sunday. A departmental inquiry has been ordered, he said. PTI



Congress helped BJP win in Thiruvananthapuram Corporation, while the BJP supported the Congress in Kollam Corporation

M.A. BABY
CPI(M) general secretary



Himanta Biswa Sarma at a rally in Karbi Anglong ahead of Assam Assembly election, on Sunday. ANI

Bongaigaon's open secret: BJP cadres back party rebel over AGP candidate

Abhinav Lakshman
BONGAIGAON

On a rainy Friday morning, the field at the local secondary school in Bongaigaon town is being prepared for a campaign meeting of Diptimayee Choudhury, MLA of the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), a party that emerged out of the Assam agitation. But there are barely any flags of the AGP's ally, the Bharatiya Janata Party, at the meeting venue, though Union Minister and BJP leader Sarbananda Sonowal was scheduled to speak for Ms. Choudhury.

The Bongaigaon Assembly constituency, part of the Barpeta Lok Sabha constituency, the region known as one of the starting points of the Assam agitation, goes to the polls on April 9, along with the rest of Assam. The ruling National Democratic Alliance has allocated the seat to the AGP, which has held it for the past 40 years. However, even as BJP workers campaign for Ms. Choudhury, a section of saffron party cadres has also been supporting her rival, Chakradhar Das, a former BJP leader now contesting as an Independent candidate after being denied ticket.

Mr. Das was among the nine BJP members the party expelled on Friday, including two contesting as Independents in the neighbouring Barpeta constituency.

'A good chance as well'

Later that day, as the BJP's district leadership met Ms. Choudhury at the party office in Bongaigaon town, workers from both the parties outside spoke of Mr. Das having a "good chance as well".

Parikshit Ray, once an AGP loyalist but now with the BJP, said, "He [Mr. Das] is secretly fighting under the BJP. He has done so much work for the people here. I have even helped him arrange a couple of public meetings in areas I am responsible for in the past couple of days. Even if he wins, it is going to benefit the people of Bongaigaon."

A section of party workers speaks of "nepotism" in having Ms. Choudhury contest the seat, citing the fact that she is the wife of Phani Bhushan Choudhury, Barpeta MP. He had held the Bongaigaon Assembly seat consistently from the 1980s till 2024, when he was elected to the Lok Sabha. In the byelection that followed, Ms. Choudhury won by nearly 35,000 votes, with a turnout of about 1.42 lakh. During the 2021 Assembly election, the constituency had around 1.76 lakh voters.

In the New Bongaigaon railway colony, where a large number of Bengali Hindus and Muslims live, posters of Mr. Das from the days he was seeking BJP ticket still hang on lamp posts.

Abdul Khaleque, a 50-year-old pan-shop owner who has lived all his life in Bongaigaon, said, "We don't concern ourselves too much. We just go and vote on the polling day. What can we say when the Chief Minister says things like, 'Trouble the miyas [a pejorative for Muslims with roots in Bangladesh] as much as you can'."

While Muslims are a minority in the constituency, the majority population comprises Koch Rajbongshis and Bengali Hindus, many of whom are categorised as Other Backward Class.

Though the Himanta Biswa Sarma Cabinet last year cleared a proposal to include the Koch Rajbongshis on the Scheduled Tribes list, a long-standing demand of the community, the issue has not featured prominently in the NDA's campaign strategy.

'A double-engine govt. will de-risk people from political feuds hurting development'

If a State government has '24x7 animosity towards the Centre, the people will suffer', says Kerala BJP president Rajeev Chandrasekhar; calling the party's performance in the 2025 local body elections in the State a 'big jump forward', he slams 'fake narratives' against the BJP among minorities

INTERVIEW

Rajeev Chandrasekhar

S.R. Praveen
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Rajeev Chandrasekhar, the Bharatiya Janata Party's Kerala unit president, has been leading the party's charge to make a dent in the Left Democratic Front-United Democratic Front duopoly in the State. He has his task cut out in the Nemom constituency, where he contests against incumbent MLA and General Education Minister V. Sivankutty of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and former Congress MLA K.S. Sabarinadhan. Edited excerpts from an interview:

BJP had a major breakthrough when it won the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation in the local body elections in 2025. But at the same time, the party only had a total vote share of 14.76% across Kerala, compared with nearly 20% in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Are you a bit worried ahead of the Assembly election?

Local body elections are typically not fought along party lines. For us, the local body polls marked a big jump forward. We fielded almost 22,000 candidates, much more

than before. The vote share may be at variance with the Lok Sabha election. But the seats that we got spanned the entire State. Earlier, we were restricted to certain pockets around Palakkad and Thiruvananthapuram or Thrissur. One of the regions where we had a major loss in votes was Thrissur. That had a lot to do with candidate selection and mistakes in campaign management, due to which we went from 40% in Lok Sabha [polls] to 20% in local body elections in the district. So if you take that one aberration out, we did extremely well.

You have been carrying out an aggressive outreach towards minority communities — both Muslim and Christian. Do you think you can overcome the apprehensions of these communities, whether it be the issues faced by Muslims or the attacks on nuns and churches in some BJP-ruled States?

Thirty years of fake narratives about the BJP have been force-fed to the minorities, that we are communal and we care only about the Hindus. During the 2024 Lok Sabha election campaign in Pozhiyoor in Thiruvananthapuram, an old lady told me, "I am ready to support you, but you should tell your people not to burn our churches." After I became the party president, we have made it a point to go and meet Malayalis across



the State to share our developmental vision and reassure them that we will not harm anyone. Regarding incidents in the North, neither I nor the BJP can speak for all 140 crore Indians, or for all Hindus. If there are crazy individuals out there, who take law into their own hands, the laws of those States must be enforced. I have given an assurance that whenever there is a Malayali in trouble, you can count on me.

Most of these attacks are allegedly carried out by the Bajrang Dal and Vishva Hindu Parishad. Do you think their actions are detrimental to the BJP's chances in Kerala?

I cannot speak for them. In Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Jharkhand, there are anti-conversion laws being passed even by Congress governments, because they consider that it is a huge threat to the indigenous communities. Congress MPs from Kerala go to Chhattisgarh for photo-ops with nuns, but not a single local Congressman participates. They will not, because of

the dynamics there.

The BJP is placing itself as an alternative to the LDF and the UDF. The LDF and the UDF have criticised the BJP-led Union government on disaster relief funds for Kerala, particularly after the 2018 floods or the landslide in Wayanad. Do you think these allegations will affect your prospects?

When a government is not able to deliver, they will find somebody to blame, which is what they are doing against the Centre. They have been unable to prove in the Supreme Court that the Centre has been unfair to the State. When the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF) balance shows so much money, on what account can the Centre give more?

But doesn't the Centre provide special packages usually when such disasters happen in BJP-ruled States?

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, every rupee has to be properly accounted for. For instance, when there is a

disaster in Himachal Pradesh, it will have to give accounts of where its SDRF money is. Only then can it make the claim for additional top-up funds. That the Kerala government is not ready to do.

On that note, what do you think of the concept of 'double-engine government' of the BJP at the Centre and the State?

In a federal democracy, if you have a State government which has 24x7 animosity towards the Centre, the people of the State will suffer. Double-engine government means there is an agreement around basic problems that need to be solved. In some cases, even when the government is not of the ruling party at the Centre, effective cooperation is possible. For instance, it had worked for Naveen Patnaik's government in Odisha.

But in Odisha too, you ran a campaign for a 'double-engine government'. So, does it also imply that you will not benefit unless it is a BJP government in the State?

No. Rather the opposite. Double-engine government de-risks the people from any political conflict coming in the way of their development.

The BJP's major allegation is that the LDF government has

failed the State across all sectors. However, the Union government's own agencies such as the NITI Aayog have given Kerala high rankings in health and education in the past 10 years. The Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) rankings had also improved from 28 to 1. How do you explain this contradiction?

It is not a contradiction at all. The metric of EoDB is not the same as attracting investments or creating jobs. Kerala today has the highest unemployment in India. EoDB is a sample survey focused on the businesses already in Kerala, not on those outside looking to invest. So, when there is little business activity in Kerala, you are only sampling what is already here.

Both the LDF and the UDF are accusing each other of having a deal with the BJP. How do you view these allegations? Whom do you consider to be the main opponent among the two?

At one level, it is laughable. I must also thank them for accepting that the BJP is the 'A-team' as both of them accuse each other of being the 'B-team' of the BJP. It is bizarre for two parties who are in a formal political alliance in every other State to be alleging this.

The deal allegation is a desperate attempt to consolidate Muslim votes.

Vijay follows in the footsteps of Tamil Nadu politicians with a penchant for dual contests

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

When actor-politician C. Joseph Vijay announced on Sunday that he would contest his first Assembly election from two urban constituencies — Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchi East — he was following an established precedent in Tamil Nadu politics, of leaders who enter the fray simultaneously from two Assembly constituencies, though few debutants adopt such a strategy.

Mr. Vijay has not cited any specific reason for his decision and remains inaccessible to the media. His fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam is making its electoral debut in the 2026 Assembly poll.

In 1991, J. Jayalalitha (as her name was spelt then), an actor-turned-politician and political heir of former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran, initially filed her nomination from Kan-geyam in the then-Periyar



Giant leap: TVK chief and actor Vijay is set to contest his first Assembly election from Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchi East. ANI

district. This was her second Assembly election, having earlier won from Bodinayakanur in 1989 while leading a faction of the AIADMK.

On April 18, 1991, she announced that she would also contest from Bargur in Dharmapuri district. Responding to questions, Jayalalitha clarified that the move was not due to fear of defeat. "I will win from any constituency as I am sure of the people's support. But some crank has issued a statement that he will commit suicide after

filing nomination in my constituency in order to countermand the election. The second nomination is just for safety's sake," she said, according to *The Hindu* archives. The AIADMK was then allied with the Congress.

A month later, former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated during an election rally in Sriperumbudur. When elections were eventually held, a massive sympathy wave resulted in a landslide victory for Jayalalitha's alliance. She won both seats and la-

ter vacated Kangeyam. However, in 1996, she was defeated in Bargur amid a strong anti-corruption wave.

In 2001, Jayalalitha surprised many by filing nominations from four constituencies — Bargur, Bhuvanagiri, Andipatti, and Krishnagiri — despite the Representation of the People Act allowing candidates to contest from only two seats. She was also facing disqualification due to convictions in corruption cases. Her decision to file from four constituencies was widely seen as an attempt to shift public focus away from her legal troubles.

Dual contest, dual loss
In the same election, Puthiya Tamilagam leader K. Krishnasamy contested from two reserved constituencies — Ottapidaram, where he was the sitting MLA, and Valparai. However, his party, which had been allotted 10 seats by

the DMK, failed to win any of them, and he himself lost in both constituencies.

A year later, during byelections in three constituencies, former DMK MLA Chengai Sivam filed nominations in all three as an Independent candidate. Strangely, while his papers were rejected in Achara-pakkam (Reserved), the Returning Officer at Saidapet accepted it. In Vaniyambadi, the Returning Officer initially announced that Mr. Sivam's nomination was rejected, but later said it would be re-scrutinised.

Interestingly, in 1980, M.G. Ramachandran and fellow actor-politician S.S. Rajendran, both formerly of the DMK, filed nominations from the same two constituencies — Andipatti and Madurai West — on AIADMK ticket. Eventually, MGR withdrew from Andipatti and the SSR from Madurai West, and both went on to win their respective seats.

Amit Shah promises to introduce UCC in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) would be introduced in Assam if the BJP forms the government for the third straight term.

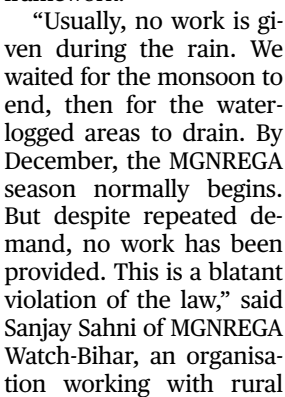
Addressing a rally in western Assam's Tihu, he said the UCC would have a provision to ban polygamy. "The move is aimed at bringing uniformity in civil laws and strengthening social reforms in Assam," he added.

Uttarakhand was the first State to pass and implement the UCC in 2025. Gujarat passed a Bill in March to implement the UCC. The Himanta Biswa Sarma-led Assam government had earlier passed the Assam Prohibition of Polygamy Bill in November 2025, seeking to criminalise the practice of having more than one spouse simultaneously.

Biju Janata Dal Rajya Sabha member Sasmit Patra on Saturday resigned from the Parliamentary Standing Committee on IT and Communications, protesting against chairperson Nishikant Dubey's remarks against Biju Patnaik. Mr. Dubey on Friday alleged that the former Odisha Chief Minister (Biju Patnaik) was a "link" between the U.S. government, the CIA, and Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru. He further alleged that Patnaik provided patronage to the Charbatia air base in Odisha, which was used by the U.S. Mr. Patra said he was attempting to distort history and malign a "revered leader" for political gains.

Uncertainty continues

There is no clarity on when the new scheme under the VB-G RAM G Act will be implemented on the ground, as the Centre is still hold-



workers. Facing repeated rejections, around 16,000 workers – most of them women – gathered at the district headquarters to demand work. A delegation also travelled to Delhi on March 25 to meet senior officials in the Rural Development Ministry.

“The district officials claim they have instructions not to start any new work. But the Ministry officials insist that no such order exists,” Mr. Sahni said. He wonders whether it is

lack of information on whether there is an informal signal from the Centre to stop all work under the MGNREGS.

In Dungarpur district of Rajasthan, similar complaints have emerged. At Balwarha panchayat, around 40 women workers arrived on March 23 to complete paperwork for April's work cycle. Panchayat officials asked them to return later, citing a lack

Financial propriety
“If expenditure is incurred beyond the sanctioned cost and the estimate is put up for approval on post facto basis, scrutiny of estimate by competent authority gets by-passed and only option left is to sanction it as a fait accompli. This

“As soon as it becomes apparent that the expenditure on a work or project is likely to exceed the amount provided thereof

The Railways had spent ₹6,19,837.90 crore against the sanctioned grant of ₹6,47,031.69 crore registering a net saving of ₹27,193.69 crore in 2022-23.

The event was attended by the Cuban Ambassador to India, Juan Carlos Mar-



“Not only did they [India] fail to condemn the assassination of the Supreme Leader... they also created the feeling through the

The statement, signed by "Lt. Gen." A. Raman, named two "Second Lieutenants" of the Wung Region as the leaders of the assailants, who fired indiscriminately after declaring that they had orders to shoot.

5	1	4	9	7	8	2	3	6
8	2	3	6	4	5	1	7	9
7	6	9	3	2	1	5	8	4
9	3	6	8	1	4	7	5	2
2	8	1	7	5	6	9	4	3
4	5	7	2	9	3	8	6	1
6	7	8	1	3	2	4	9	5
1	9	5	4	6	7	3	2	8
3	4	2	5	8	9	6	1	7

Many people spend most of their time pursuing worldly pleasures such as material possessions, status, or enjoyment. However, such experiences do not provide lasting satisfaction or permanent results. Eventually, people realise that what they once believed to be permanent is actually temporary. Realising later in life that time was spent on temporary pursuits can bring regret or a sense of lost meaning. Understanding life's true purpose early helps avoid this and encourages wise use of time. According to spiritual philosophy, the human body is influenced by three qualities: *Sattva* (purity and wisdom), *Rajas* (activity and desire), and *Tamas* (ignorance and inertia). To attain lasting happiness and spiritual growth, one must cultivate *Sattva* guna while reducing influence of *Rajas* and *Tamas*.

When the ‘promise’ is not the ‘policy’

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

Ever regretted buying an insurance policy? Yeah? Me too! It happens to many of us and for various reasons. One of them is mis-selling.

This column often advises readers to do homework before committing money to an insurance policy, warning them against ‘mis-buying’. But what is mis-selling?

If you have bought an insurance policy relying on advice and discover later that you have to pay annual premiums on what was sold to you as a single premium policy, if you realise there is a lock-in period for exiting the policy that you did not know about, if you find that the ‘mandatory’ policy you were pressured into taking was optional.... chances are you are a victim of mis-selling.

Union Finance Minister, Nirmala Sitharaman, recently warned banks quite sternly against mis-selling insurance and advised them to focus on their core business of lending.

But once upon a time bank margins were so squeezed that the opportunity to cross-sell insurance to earn fee-based income was a blessing.

It suited a rapidly expanding insurance industry which needed a wide and deep financial services network. So was born bancassurance and it has contributed significantly to insurance sales over the decades.

Pressure selling

Insurance, it is said, is always sold and never bought. The reluctant and ignorant prospect has to be convinced. Badgering, scare tactics and the lure of saving tax helps the process.

Almost all intermediaries hard-sell insurance, but some add false promises, partial information and even outright misinformation. It could be about the nature of the policy, suitability, pricing, what you are entitled to from the policy or what you are obligated to do to maintain it.

Some deception is ‘expected’ in marketing and selling, after all that’s why it is said, “let the buyer beware”. But when you read about an 80-year old who was sold a 100-year term policy, words fail you.

Insurance is an intangible product, complex and trust-based. Add to this customer reluctance, low financial literacy and even some active revulsion about the product. This is the opportunity for mis-selling.

However, aggressive selling is not necessarily mis-selling. The former is persistent and high-pitched. When it involves false promises or strategic silence on some policy features, it becomes mis-selling.

Mis-selling is not outright fraud either. It exists in a grey zone where the disclaimers and documents say one thing with the signatures prove it. But the implied benefits and understanding of the policy are different.

Like a long-term insurance policy sold as “just like a fixed deposit, but even better” to someone investing retirement savings. Like a hospitalisation policy that is projected as a complete or unlimited cover. Like a ‘compulsory’ home fire policy to go with a home loan.

When reality clashes with expectations, trust is lost. On the policy, the seller, the insurance company and industry. Maybe even on insurance itself. What is devastating is that it happens at the moment of the paying customer’s deepest need.

We will see the hows and whys of insurance mis-selling in the forthcoming instalments of CoverNote. And explore how you as a customer can safeguard yourself against it, or seek remedies when needed.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



Regardless of how wars unfold, investors must stay prepared to protect their portfolios. .ILLUSTRATION: SAINATH B.

When the cannons boom: stock markets in wartime

War may come and war may go, but the stock markets go on for ever. But there’s a catch, markets can fall, keep falling and remain bearish in the short term; staying invested when it bleeds is the real magic for building wealth

BOURSES AND BULLETS

Vaishali R Venkat

When cannons roar and nations descend into conflict, it sets off a cascading effect. The impact ripples far beyond battlefields, reaching deep into financial markets. Contrary to the conventional wisdom, war does not always trigger chaos or crashes.

History shows markets can plunge into volatility, remain resilient, or eventually recover after periods of intense sell-offs.

The hail of bullets have even brought down the curtains on markets for extended periods. So, no two conflicts affect markets alike. But regardless of how wars unfold, investors must stay prepared to protect their portfolios. Let’s rewind the clock of wars and markets...

World War I

On June 28, 1914, Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, was assassinated, in Sarajevo (then part of Austro-Hungarian Empire). Following this, tensions escalated and Europe edged towards a wider conflict, which culminated in the outbreak of World War I.

The financial panic intensified so much and stock exchanges across Europe were shut. In the United States, the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE) downed its shutters for nearly 19 weeks from July 31 to December 11, 1914. This suspension is said to be the longest hiatus in the global financial system. Gripped by fear and uncertainty, investors rushed towards safety. The demand for

gold surged, triggering heavy selloffs in stocks. To improve economic stability, the U.S. government invoked the Aldrich-Vreeland Act of 1908, allowing banks to issue emergency currency backed by securities rather than gold.

The War put an end to the international Gold Standard monetary system, as most warring nations halted the free conversion of currency into gold and began hoarding gold reserves. The U.S. continued to honour gold convertibility within the U.S while restricting the outflow of gold through an export embargo. Further, the disruption triggered an acute liquidity crunch, as banks struggled to supply cash.

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World War II

In September 1939, World War II unfolded with a different economic impact when Adolf Hitler’s Nazi Germany invaded Poland. Markets remained open but the crisis shifted from liquidity to that of physical capacity, as widespread destruction of industry and infrastructure across Europe and East Asia crippled production. During World War II (1939-1945), the stock markets moved in phases rather than a straight line. Historical S&P index data indicated that the market initially surged around 14% in the

month after Germany’s invasion of Poland in 1939, only to decline by about 6% in 1940 as fears of a wider war intensified. The market eventually bottomed in 1942, with the S&P 500 reaching its low.

pressure, Arab oil embargo, 2000s dot-com crash, U.S. 9/11 attack, 2008 financial crisis, inflationary spirals, hyperinflation, COVID-19 pandemic, political chaos, scams and scandals, bank collapses, black swan events and what not. War may come and war may go, but the stock markets go on for ever. But there’s a catch. Markets can fall, keep falling and remain bearish in the short term. However, this uncertainty is not a bug but a toll for long-term wealth creation. Investing is easy but staying invested when it bleeds red is the real magic.

1973 Yom Kippur War

During the Yom Kippur War, stock markets did not collapse immediately but the real damage came from the oil shock that followed. On October 6, 1973, during the Jewish holy day of Yom Kippur, Egyptian and Syrian forces launched a surprise offensive against Israel. In response, on October 17, 1973, Arab members of Organization of Arab Petroleum Exporting Countries (OAPEC) imposed an oil embargo on the West and slashed production, driving oil prices to quadruple from \$3 to \$12 per barrel approximately by early 1974. After the oil shock, oil exports were priced in U.S. dollars, increasing global demand for U.S. dollars. This triggered one of the worst bear markets in modern history, with the S&P 500 falling roughly 40-45% between 1973 and 1974, over a period of nearly two years.

War may come and go

Across a century of turmoil, stock markets have endured two World Wars, the Great De-

pression, Arab oil embargo, 2000s dot-com crash, U.S. 9/11 attack, 2008 financial crisis, inflationary spirals, hyperinflation, COVID-19 pandemic, political chaos, scams and scandals, bank collapses, black swan events and what not. War may come and war may go, but the stock markets go on for ever. But there’s a catch. Markets can fall, keep falling and remain bearish in the short term. However, this uncertainty is not a bug but a toll for long-term wealth creation. Investing is easy but staying invested when it bleeds red is the real magic.

‘Lost decades’

Beware! A stark counterexample: Japan’s index Nikkei 225 peaked at nearly 39,000 on December 29, 1989, and took nearly 34 years to bounce back to that level in February 2024 and crossing 40,000 in March 2024. The bursting of Japan’s late-1980s asset bubble led to deflation and decades of slow growth, known as the Lost Decades.

The stock market is a labyrinth that no brilliant mind can decode with complete accuracy. Yet one can navigate this ocean with planning and patience. Do not indulge in panic selling; if there is no immediate need for cash, do not exit in red; avoid making hurried changes to your portfolio; maintain adequate liquidity for emergencies; continue your SIPs and use declines as an opportunity to average your investments. Above all, be patient, stay disciplined, and diversify: never put all your eggs in one basket.

(The writer is an NISM & CRI-SIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM’s Research Analyst module)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.50 onwards	10,501 onwards	2,100 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.50% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75- 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.75- 12.55	10,319-11,262	2,064-2,252	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95- 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	9.85-11.65	10,587-11,034	2,117-2,207	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance
Rates and charges as of March 25

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.40-9.45	9,995 - 10,489	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.55-10.70	10,031 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.40	10,078 - 10,477	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.50 onwards	10,258 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.00-11.50	10,138 - 10,996	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.20	10,043 - 10,428	No processing fees till 31.03.2026

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/existing customers with 6 months relationship with bank
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on March 25

How ETFs fit into your portfolio

THINKINVESTOR

For a chosen benchmark, whether broad-cap or large-cap index, it is best to pick an ETF with high liquidity

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

You can set up systematic investment plans (SIPs) on exchange-traded funds (ETFs) to accumulate wealth to achieve life goals. You can also actively trade ETFs to capture short-term gains from their price movements. In this article, we discuss how to set up a simple process to do both.

The core-satellite framework refers to the process of simultaneously creating goal-based (core) portfolios and a trading (satellite) portfolio. The objective is to profit from short-term trends in the market without compromising on your life goals.

Now, suppose you invest in an ETF on the Nifty Index. You can set up an SIP matching the time horizon of a life goal. For instance, if one of your goals is for eight years, you can set up a monthly SIP for eight years. You can choose the same ETF for your satellite portfolio.

The difference is that you should time your entry and exit for your satellite portfolio. Because you are trading the same ETF with two different objectives, the cash flows must be easily identifiable to efficiently manage the investments. You must, therefore, have two different trading accounts –one account earmarked for the core and the other for the satellite.

You can have one account in your family member’s name and the other in your name.

This is important for operational efficiency. You will trade frequently in your satellite portfolio, buying when the Nifty Index declines and selling when the index hits your price target.

This trading account must be linked to a bank account that is only meant for your satellite portfolio. The other account from where you set up SIPs on the ETF must be linked to a master savings account from where you manage all the SIPs for your goal-based investments (core portfolio).

That way, whenever you rebalance (sell units to realise gains) your ETF investments, the proceeds are credited to your master savings account. This helps you to easily identify the sale proceeds and reinvest in bank deposits earmarked for that goal. ETFs are typically passive products. Such products are expected to mirror their benchmark index before costs.

So, all ETFs on the same benchmark will generate similar returns. This moderates regret that you could suffer from when you invest in active funds because the funds you did not choose could perform better than the ones you did.

For a chosen benchmark, whether broad-cap or large-cap index, it is best to pick an ETF with high liquidity.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

LONG WAIT ENDS

Happy we were able to win after 13 years, says MI captain Hardik



EMMANUAL YOGINI

It's been a long wait. 13 years is a long time [winning first game of the season]. Very glad that we were finally able to do it. We knew the pitch was good and felt 221 was always gettable. Rohit and Rickelton were brilliant. Shardul has a big heart, and we are really happy for him — Mumbai Indians captain Hardik Pandya.

NOT OUR CALL

Direct the question to CA, says Rahane on Green not bowling



EMMANUAL YOGINI

KKR skipper Ajinkya Rahane said that the question of why all-rounder Cameron Green was not bowling “should be directed to Cricket Australia”. “When Green starts to bowl, the combination will be slightly different. At the moment, we have to see the balance. So hopefully, Green starts to bowl soon,” Rahane said after the match.

HEARTFELT

We miss our family members: Patidar on stampede victims



K. MURALI KUMAR

RCB skipper Rajat Patidar paid tribute to the 11 persons who died in the stampede last year. “You feel bad when you miss your family member. I say family member because everyone who supports us is family. We miss them,” Patidar said in the post-match press conference after the victory over SRH in the IPL opener.

SANGASPEAK

‘A good trade is when both sides are slightly happy and unhappy’



CSK

In trades, the best outcome is when both sides are happy but also slightly unhappy. We were sad to see Sanju go. But it was something that was going to happen. We brought in Jaddu and Curran, which balanced our squad. Both teams might feel they could have got more — that usually means it's a good trade — Kumar Sangakkara.

Rickelton and Rohit sizzle as MI breaks a jinx

The duo's blistering 148-run opening stand powers team to first win in season-opener since 2012; Shardul shines with three scalps; Rahane, Raghuvanshi score half-centuries

IPL-19

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Rohit Sharma's off-side masterclass complemented by Ryan Rickelton's on-side dominance helped Mumbai Indians end a 14-year wait and begin their Indian Premier League campaign with a commanding six-wicket win over Kolkata Knight Riders at the Wankhede Stadium on Sunday night.

Chasing 221, Mumbai Indians barely broke a sweat as Rohit and Rickelton stitched together a blistering 148-run opening stand off just 72 balls against a hapless KKR bowling attack.

The platform ensured the chase never stretched the home side's batting resources, with Naman Dhir sealing the win by off-driving Anukul Roy for four off the first ball of the final over — handing MI their first season-opening victory since 2012.

Rohit began cautiously, opening his account with a thick inside-edged four off Blessing Muzarabani, one of three IPL debutants for KKR.

But once set, the MI veteran produced a vintage display of off-side stroke-play. He lofted Muzarabani for an inside-out six in the fourth over, greeted Varun Chakravarthi with the shot of the night, and later sent Kartik Tyagi soaring



Dazzling show: Rohit and Rickelton were on song, belting boundaries at will to kick-start Mumbai Indians' campaign. EMMANUAL YOGINI

over covers. In between, the crisp drives through cover-point flowed freely, drawing loud “Rohit, Rohit” chants from the Wankhede crowd.

Rickelton, meanwhile, dominated the leg-side, capitalising on wayward lines from the KKR bowlers. The visitors' woes were compounded by cap-

tain Ajinkya Rahane leaving the field after the third over due to cramps, depriving them of on-field leadership during a crucial phase.

Earlier, Rahane had led KKR's charge with the bat after being put in.

Along with Finn Allen, he powered the side to a brisk start before Shardul

Thakur's golden arm turned the tide. Making his MI debut, Shardul struck in each of his first three overs, first dismissing Allen with a knuckle ball before removing Cameron Green with a clever change of pace.

Rahane, however, remained aggressive, welcoming Mayank Markande

with two sixes and continuing his assault before Jasprit Bumrah briefly stemmed the flow. Shardul eventually dismissed Rahane in the 14th over, but late contributions ensured KKR finished with a competitive total — one that ultimately proved insufficient against Mumbai's dominant opening act.



Flying high: Shardul checked the Knight Riders' progress with vital strikes. EMMANUAL YOGINI

SCOREBOARD

KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS

Ajinkya Rahane c Hardik b Shardul 67 (40b, 3x4, 5x6), Finn Allen c Tilak b Shardul 37 (17b, 6x4, 2x6), Cameron Green c Rutherford b Shardul 18 (10b, 1x4, 1x6), Angkrish Raghuvanshi c Tilak b Hardik 51 (29b, 6x4, 2x6), Rinku Singh (not out) 33 (21b, 4x4), Ramandeep Singh (not out) 4 (4b); Extras (lb-2, nb-1, w-7): 10; Total (for four wkts. in 20 overs): 220.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-69 (Allen, 5.2 overs), 2-109 (Green, 8.5), 3-145 (Rahane, 13.3), 4-205 (Raghuvanshi, 18.3).

MUMBAI INDIANS BOWLING
Boult 4-0-38-0, Hardik 3-0-39-1, Ghazanfar 4-0-51-0, Bumrah 4-0-35-0, Shardul 4-0-39-3, Markande 1-0-16-0.

MUMBAI INDIANS
Ryan Rickelton run out 81 (43b, 4x4, 8x6), Rohit Sharma c Anukul b Vaibhav 78 (38b, 6x4, 6x6), Suryakumar Yadav (Impact Player for Bumrah) c Rinku b Tyagi 16 (8b, 3x4), Tilak Varma c

sub (Pandey) b Narine 20 (14b, 4x4), Hardik Pandya (not out) 18 (11b, 3x4), Naman Dhir (not out) 5 (2b, 1x4); Extras (lb-2, nb-1, w-3): 6; Total (for four wkts. in 19.1 overs): 224.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-148 (Rohit, 11.5), 2-179 (Suryakumar, 14.2), 3-184 (Rickelton, 15.2), 4-215 (Tilak, 18.4).

KNIGHT RIDERS BOWLING
Vaibhav 4-0-52-1, Muzarabani 3-0-34-0, Varun 4-0-48-0, Tyagi (Impact Player for Allen) 4-0-43-1, Narine 3-0-30-1, Anukul 1.1-0-15-0.

Toss: MI; **PoM:** Shardul. Mumbai Indians won by six wickets with five balls to spare.

Next assignment

KKR: April 2 vs. SRH
Kolkata, 7.30 p.m.

MI: April 4 vs. DC
Delhi, 3.30 p.m.

RR and CSK hit reset button, eye positive start

Tarun Shastry
GUWAHATI

There have been four occasions in the IPL when the Chennai Super Kings began its campaign away from home.

Each time, it has gone on to reach the playoffs, and on two of those occasions — 2018 and 2023 — it lifted the title in dramatic fashion.

In the 19th edition, Super Kings will take on Rajasthan Royals at the ACA-Bar sapara Stadium here on Monday. History, therefore, offers an intriguing subplot — but this contest carries layers far beyond numbers, as it is shaped as much by transition as by recent form.

Both teams come in after underwhelming 2025 seasons. CSK missed the playoffs for a second straight year — a first in its history — raising questions about depth and renewal. RR endured a tougher campaign, finishing ninth after a slump that included seven consecutive defeats.

The Royals have responded with a significant overhaul, revamping personnel as well as its support staff and management



Key battle: CSK's think-tank would want to see the back of Suryavanshi at the earliest. RITU RAJ KONWAR

structure. Yet, a strong core remains.

Yashasvi Jaiswal remains central at the top, while Vaibhav Suryavanshi adds explosiveness.

The middle-order, which struggled last season, will rely on Shimron Hetmyer and Dhruv Jurel, now strengthened by Ravindra Jadeja.

With the ball, much will

depend on Jofra Archer up front, along with the experienced Sandeep Sharma. The addition of Ravi Bishnoi lends variety to the spin attack.

The visitor, too, has embraced change, injecting youth into its line-up. Ayush Mhatre and Dewald Brevis (though unavailable for the tie) bring fresh energy, while Prashant

Veer and Kartik Sharma add finishing power alongside Shivam Dube. Ruturaj Gaikwad's leadership, combined with Sanju Samson's versatility, adds balance.

However, the five-time champion will be without M.S. Dhoni, who has been ruled out for two weeks with a calf strain — an early setback.

Today's match

Rajasthan Royals vs Chennai Super Kings
Guwahati, 7.30 p.m.
HEAD-TO-HEAD
Played: 31
RR 15 | CSK 16
PREVIOUS MEETING
RR won by six wickets, 2025
LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1, SS SELECT 1, 2 & JIOTSTAR



Yes, Brevis is out and is currently in rehab. Hopefully, it won't be too long before he returns. We've invested in youth and Indian talent, and there's real energy in the group. The first game is always a good barometer

FLEMING
CSK head coach

The weather could also play a role. Persistent rain and drizzle here add uncertainty as both sides look to make an early statement. CSK will hope history repeats itself, while RR aims to turn promise into performance.

‘We felt Parag was the best fit to lead’

Tarun Shastry
GUWAHATI

Ahead of their IPL season opener, Rajasthan Royals head coach Kumar Sangakkara and Chennai Super Kings' Stephen Fleming offered insights into team strategy, leadership decisions, and early challenges.

For RR, the spotlight is on the appointment of Riyan Parag as captain following the departure of Sanju Samson.

“Yes, we had multiple candidates, including Sandeep Sharma and Ravindra Jadeja. We had a very structured process with strict parameters. All of them were capable of captaining the side. But we felt Parag was the best fit. The conversations were tough, but he handled them really well,” Sangakkara said.

For CSK, Fleming downplayed suggestions that the opening match signals a transition phase without M.S. Dhoni. “It’s just a game without him. He’s still heavily involved in the side, and his influence remains very strong”.

‘I only think of being a match-winner’

S. Shrivathsan

‘Harpreet Brar’ and ‘hype’ seldom get mentioned in the same sentence.

The Punjab Kings left-arm spinner has influenced many an IPL match with his miserly spells, especially in the last three seasons. But Harpreet has often flown under the radar as his numbers — 35 wickets in 49 games at 8.03 — do not tell the whole story.

Back in red and blue to quietly go about his business in IPL 2026, the 30-year-old is eager to remain a pivotal piece of the PBKS puzzle. “I’ve never paid attention to it (spotlight not being on him), but I’ve been put under pressure after being told that this is happening (laughs). Whenever I play, I only think of becoming a match-winner,” Harpreet told *The Hindu* during a virtual interaction on Sunday.

“I want to help the team cross the line. Sometimes I succeed and sometimes I do not,” he added.

In a tournament where the bowlers are put under the pump from the very beginning, Harpreet operates



Harpreet. PUNJAB KINGS

with a simple mantra.

“I never pre-plan such things (whether to attack the batters or defend); But I always think about taking a wicket. Only when I take a wicket can I grow as a player.”

Being led by Shreyas Iyer has helped Harpreet immensely. “Shreyas is the best captain I’ve played under. He has an on-field attitude; he talks a lot. He allows us to do what we want and asks us to play without pressure. If a Punjabi guy gets such backing, he can win the world.”

For now, the tweaker would not mind clinching PBKS' maiden IPL trophy.

INBRIEF



Sabalenka sinks Gauff for second straight Miami title

Aryna Sabalenka won her second straight Miami Open title on Sunday beating Coco Gauff 6-2, 4-6, 6-3 to complete a “Sunshine Double” Indian Wells-Miami sweep. The World No.1 from Belarus, fresh off her first triumph in the California desert, became the fifth woman – and the first since Iga Swiatek in 2022 – to win both of the elite early-season hardcourt WTA 1000 titles.



India U-23 men thrash Bhutan in tri-nation championship

The India U-23 men’s football team pumped five past Bhutan in the U-23 Tri-Nation Championship 2026 at Yupia, Arunachal Pradesh. Suhail Ahmad Bhat (51, 81) scored a brace, while Ricky Meetei Haobam (44), Tomba Singh Haobam (79), and Muhammed Ajsal (85) netted one each. This victory takes India to the top of the table, level on points (three) with Tajikistan.



Mary Kom considers move into professional boxing

Olympic bronze medallist and six-time world champion M.C. Mary Kom on Sunday said she was considering a move into professional boxing. The 43-year-old is past the age eligibility to compete on the amateur circuit. “Although I reached a stage where age restrictions prevented me from competing further in amateur boxing for the country, a new opportunity has surfaced in professional boxing,” she said. “I am taking some time to consider it. I am working hard and trying to make a comeback.”

Martin snatches a dramatic US sprint victory, in lead

Jorge Martin overtook Francesco Bagnaia on the final lap to snatch victory in the sprint race at the US Grand Prix in Austin and take the MotoGP championship lead on Saturday. The Aprilia rider came from seventh on the grid to win a dramatic sprint in which Marco Bezzecchi crashed out and Marc Marquez also slid off the track, taking pole-sitter Fabio Di Giannantonio with him.

Indian boxers seek a strong start in Asian championships

Press Trust of India
ULAANBAATAR (MONGOLIA)

Indian boxers will aim for a good show at the Asian Championships, beginning here on Monday, as they look to make the most of their opportunities in a packed season and secure direct berths for the multi-sport events later this year. The tournament marks the first major outing in a loaded season that includes the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow (July-August), the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan (September-October) and the World Boxing Cup Finals in Uzbekistan. The finalists will earn direct qualification for Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, in line with the BFI’s selection policy.

The Indian team has been acclimatising in Mongolia training in multinational camps and sparring with boxers from Mongolia, China, Jordan and Thailand. The women’s challenge will be led by Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Nikhat Zareen (51kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), Priya (60kg), Ankushita Boro (65kg), Arundhati Choudhary (70kg), Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Pooja Rani (80kg) and Alfiya Tarannum Akram Khan Pathan (80+kg).

JAPANESE GP

Agence France-Presse
SUZUKA

Mercedes’ Kimi Antonelli won the Japanese Grand Prix on Sunday for his second straight victory, as the 19-year-old Italian became the youngest driver in Formula One history to lead the world championship standings. Antonelli took advantage of a mid-race safety car to leapfrog into the lead after a dreadful start from pole position and led home McLaren’s Oscar Piastri by 13.722sec with Ferrari’s Charles Leclerc a further 1.548sec back in third. He moved up to 72 points and leads the championship by nine points after three races, building on the first Grand Prix win of his career two weeks ago in China. “Of course it’s still too early to think about the championship but we’re on a good way,” said Antonelli. His Mercedes teammate George Russell finished fourth to drop to second in the championship stand-



I don’t know what would have happened, what the outcome would have been without the safety car, but it definitely made my life a lot easier – ANTONELLI

ings on 63 points. Leclerc is third on 49. Russell battled Piastri for the lead over the first half of the race but pitted just before the safety car which dropped him out of contention for the win. Piastri secured second in his first Grand Prix start of the season, after crashing on his way to the grid in the opener in Australia and missing the race in China because of a technical problem. Piastri led for the first half of the race before the safety car gave Antonelli his chance. McLaren’s world champion Lando Norris was fifth ahead of Ferrari’s Lewis Hamilton and Alpine’s Pierre Gasly. Red Bull’s four-time world champion Max Verstappen, the winner in Japan for the past four years, was eighth after

starting from 11th. Formula One now takes an extended break until the Miami Grand Prix on May 3.

The results: 1. Antonelli (Mercedes) 1h 28m 3.403s, 2. Piastri (McLaren) at +13.722s, 3. Leclerc (Ferrari) +15.270, 4. Russell (Mercedes) +15.754, 5. Norris (McLaren) +23.479, 6. Hamilton (Ferrari) +25.037, 7. Gasly (Alpine) +32.340, 8. Verstappen (Red Bull) +32.677, 9. Lawson (Racing Bulls) +50.180, 10. Ocon (Haas) +51.216, 11. Hulkenberg (Audi) +52.280, 12. Hadjar (Red Bull) +56.154, 13. Bortoleto (Audi) +59.078, 14. Lindblad (Racing Bulls) +59.848, 15. Sainz Jr. (Williams) +1m 05.008s, 16. Colapinto (Alpine) +1m 05.773s, 17. Perez (Cadillac) +1m 32.453s, 18. Alonso (Aston Martin) +1 lap, 19. Bottas (Cadillac) +1 lap, 20. Albon (Williams) +2 laps. **Retirements: 21st lap:** Bearman (Haas), **31st lap:** Stroll (Aston Martin). **Championship standings: Drivers:** 1. Antonelli 72 points, 2. Russell 63, 3. Leclerc 49, 4. Hamilton 41, 5. Norris 25, 6. Piastri 21, 7. Bearman 17, 8. Gasly 15, 9. Verstappen 12, 10. Lawson 10, 11. Lindblad 4, 12. Hadjar 4, 13. Bortoleto 2, 14. Sainz Jr. 2, 15. Ocon 1, 16. Colapinto 1. **Constructors:** 1. Mercedes 135 points, 2. Ferrari 90, 3. McLaren 46, 4. Haas 18, 5. Alpine 16, 6. Red Bull 16, 7. Racing Bulls 14, 8. Audi 2, 9. Williams 2.

Lights to flag

1 Antonelli (19y 7m 4d) breaks Hamilton’s record (22y 4m 6d) to become the youngest driver to lead the drivers’ championship

1 Antonelli is the first driver to win multiple races as a teenager, and the first Italian to win consecutive races since Ascari in 1953

1 The Italian is the first whose first two wins have both been hat-tricks (pole, race win, fastest lap)

6 After three races, Red Bull sits P6 in the constructors’ standings. Only in 2006, 2007 and 2008 was it in such a position after the first three races

6 For the first time since his Suzuka debut in 2009, Hamilton has finished the race

THE JOURNEY IN NUMBERS AFTER THE 53-LAP RACE AT SUZUKA

Every driver who has won at Suzuka since 2004 has either gone on to bag the drivers’ title or finish at least as runner-up that season

18 Alonso and Aston Martin finally took the chequered flag in 2026

30 McLaren has become the first team to record as many as 30 top three finishes at the Japanese GP

52 Leclerc goes level with Raikkonen for the fourth most podiums by a Ferrari driver

88 Antonelli has led more laps than every other driver combined this season (Russell - 36, Leclerc - 23, Piastri - 16, Hamilton - 4)

315 Mercedes goes past Williams for most podium finishes in F1

500 The Japanese GP was the 500th round of the world championship to be won by the pole-sitter. Incidentally, the first race won from pole was also by an Italian (Farina, 1950 British GP)

Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Shivam’s career-best knock takes Nelson to a mammoth 476

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Riding on opener Shivam Singh’s career-best 231 (285b, 25x4, 8x6), Nelson amassed 476 on the second day of its TNCA first division eighth-round fixture against Jupiter at the Wahe Guru-A ground on Sunday. N.S. Harish’s seven for 146 was a standout effort despite Jupiter conceding a massive 388-run first-innings deficit. Jupiter, after being dismissed for 88 in the first innings, fought to 226 for nine in the second. Left-arm spinner Sachin Rathi followed up his first-innings six-for with five for 57 for a match-haul of 11/ 83. At IITM-Chemplast, Jolly Rovers tightened its grip against Grand Slam, declaring at 567/3. Opener B.



Shivam (Nelson, 231); Sachin (Jolly Rovers, 229) Harish (Jupiter, 7/146); Andre (Jolly Rovers, 151); Selvakumaran (Sea Hawks, 5/57); Mohamed Ali (Vijay, 114); Atheeq (Young Stars, 109 batting).

Sachin converted his overnight 129 into a splendid 229 (391b, 20x4, 2x6), while C. Andre Siddarth struck a fluent 151 (134b, 13x4, 7x6) – his maiden century – as the duo added 223 for the second wicket. S. Mohamed Ali completed a patient 114 (308b, 8x4, 2x6) as Vijay CC posted 250 against SKM at Gurunanak. Young Stars moved to 341 for seven and secured a 128-run first-innings lead over Alwarpet at SRMC. Left-hander Atheeq ur Rahman remained unbeaten on 109 (174b, 11x4, 2x6), putting his side firmly ahead.

MRC-A piled on 327, claiming a 195-run first-innings lead against Sea Hawks at A.M. Jain College. Left-arm spinner N. Selvakumaran’s five for 57 was the standout bowling effort for Sea Hawks. **The scores (round eight, day two): At IITM-Chemplast:** Jolly Rovers 567/3 decl. in 124.5 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 141, B. Sachin 229, C. Andre Siddarth 151) vs. Grand Slam 170/4 in 55 overs (L. Suryaprakash 52 batting). **At Gurunanak:** Vijay 250 in 117.3 overs (Pradosh Ranjan Paul 81, S. Mohamed Ali 114, M. Ganesh Moorthi 4/44) vs. SKM 170/4 in 60 overs (M. Mohammed Azharuddeen 49). **At Nelson Wahe Guru-A:** Jupiter SC 88 & 226/9 in 54 overs (T. Vijay

Abimanyu 40, P. Khush Bardia 46, Sachin Rathi 5/57) vs. Nelson SC 476 in 98 overs (Shivam Singh 231, S. Ritihik Easwaran 57, N.S. Harish 7/146). **At SRMC, turf:** Alwarpet 213 vs. Young Stars 341/7 in 105 overs (Rahul Ayyappan Harish 52, Nidhish S. Rajagopal 55, J. Ajay Chetan 45, M.A. Atheeq ur Rahman 109 batting, R. Rohit 40 batting). **At SSN:** Singam Puli 353 in 111.4 overs (Ch. Jitendra Kumar 151, U. Mukilesh 51) vs. Globe Trotters SC 191/3 in 62 overs (A.B. Dhiyash 77 batting, G. Ajitesh 67 batting). **At A.M. Jain, turf:** Sea Hawks 132 & 31/2 in 13 overs vs. MRC-A 327 in 104.5 overs (S.R. Athish 47, N.S. Chaturved 70, M. Boopathi Vaishna Kumar 46, N. Selvakumaran 5/57).

Two Indian teams stay on course for World athletics relays

ANI
CHANDIGARH

The members of the National men’s longer relay and mixed 4x100m relay squad improved their global rankings on the Road to Gaborone26, here. The World Athletics Relays will be held on May 2 and 3 in Gaborone, Botswana. It was heartbreak for the men’s 4x100m relay team as it was disqualified in the heats on Saturday. Manu T.S., Amoj Jacob, D. Chaudhary and Rajesh Ramesh were members of

the 4x400m relay team that won gold in 3:01.43s. The AFI fielded two teams in the mixed 4x100m event and members of both teams did exceedingly well. The National-B mixed 4x100m relay team won gold in 42.30s. India-A finished second in 42.34s. Maldives was third (44.53s). The National mixed 4x400m and women’s 4x100m relay squads are also strong contenders to clinch the tickets to Gaborone.

AROUND THE CITY

Rashul stars for Pattabiram Medium-pacer N. Rashul Haseef took five for seven in Pattabiram CA’s 10-wicket win over Stag CC in the Thiruvallur DCA III-B league. **The scores: II-B:** Classic 144/8 in 30 overs (K. Sachin 36, R.S. Lalith 3/40) lost to Mogappair 147/2 in 21 overs (D. Hariprasath 61, C.S. Rohit Kumar 51 n.o.). **III-B:** Lucas TVS 175/7 in 30 overs (U. Vinothkannan 55, T.S.R. Venkateswara 30) tied with Parthasarathy MCC 175/8 in 30 overs (R.V. Karthikeyan 65, S. Srivatsan 40, K.S. Laxmana Sundaram 4/34). Stag 64 in 21 overs (N. Rashul Haseef 5/7) lost to Pattabiram 66/0 in 7.4 overs (M. Vinith Kumar 51 n.o.). **IV-B:** United 135/9 in 30 overs (M. Devaraj 72) lost to Jaya Education Group 137/2 in 12 overs (V. Dinesh Kumar 82, M. Gowtham 39 n.o.). SRF 174 in 25 overs (A. Saravanan 54, A. Kumar 55, R. Abhinav 3/33, C. Jawahar 3/27) lost to SSCA 175/8 in 28.5 overs (R. Abhinav 41, E.S. Vishal Rao 66, K. Saravanan 3/47).



(Guru Nanak College), Porur (Sri Ramachandra Medical College), Vanagaram (SV High School), Injambakkam (Akshar Arbol International School), and Ottiambakkam (MS Dhoni Global School). Boys and girls aged between six and 23 are eligible. For admissions, contact 73053 22282 (Thoraipakkam), 63793 89646 (Velachery), 93618 39587 (Porur), 73056 12157 (Vanagaram), 9940 077942 (Injambakkam), 63793 89646 (Ottiambakkam). Visit www.superkingsacademy.com.

LIVE TELECAST

IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m. **Football:** European WC Qualifiers, Sony Sports Ten 5, 2, 1 & LIV, 8.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday).

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA I div. league, Jolly Rovers vs. Grand Slam (IITM-Chemplast); Vijay vs. SKM (Guru Nanak); Nelson vs. Jupiter (Nelson Wahe Guru-A); Young Stars vs. Alwarpet (SRMC, turf), Singam Puli vs. Globe Trotters (SSN); MRC-A vs. Sea Hawks (A.M. Jain), day three, 9.15 a.m.



The rotation system was introduced to ensure that everyone got their fair share of matches but now it's a system that exists either only on paper or in one's imagination because clearly, in reality, it has been given the heave-ho

R. Kaushik

Think V.V.S. Laxman, and the first number that springs to mind is 281. There is more to the classy Hyderabadi than that epochal number – as evidenced by the title of his autobiography, *281 and Beyond* – but Laxman's career will forever be defined by 281.

After all, it was that knock which changed the landscape of Indian cricket, maybe even of Test cricket. It came against all odds; Australia were sitting on a 16-Test winning streak, had battered India into submission inside three days in the opening game of a three-match series in Mumbai just 10 days previously, and had understandably enforced the follow-on in their first dig, so it made sense to strike when the iron was hot.

Understandably, because in three previous completed innings in the series, India's scores were 176, 219 and 171. For Steve Waugh to believe that 274 was far too many in the bank wasn't fanciful; his crack bowling unit had taken only 58.1 overs, spread over an overnight break, to run through India in their first dig, so it made sense to strike when the iron was hot.

But what's it they say about the best laid plans of men and mice? Despite an improved batting display in their second innings, India were still in trouble at 115 for three, Sachin Tendulkar dismissed for a second score of 10 in the match, when skipper Sourav Ganguly walked in at No. 5. Normally, he would have punched gloves with Rahul Dravid, his deputy. Instead, in what turned out to be a masterstroke, the man who greeted him in the middle was Laxman, promoted to No. 3 after his first-innings 59, the lone score of more than 25 in India's 171.

Even when Ganguly helped Laxman add 117 for the fourth wicket, Australia were in control; at the captain's dismissal, India were 42 short of making the Aussies bat again. Laxman and Dravid, maybe hurting inside at being demoted but never complaining because he was the ultimate team man, represented the last specialist pair. One more strike, and Australia were into Nayan Mongia and then the bowlers.

That one more strike, history will testify, was 376 runs and 104.1 overs in coming. Laxman and Dravid, who had had numerous grand alliances for South Zone in domestic cricket, reprised the *jugalbandi* at the grandest stage of all, batting through the entire fourth day unseparated. When Laxman was eventually dismissed on day five, he had overhauled Sunil Gavaskar's 236 not out to produce India's highest individual Test score. Dravid's masterpiece ended on 180, Ganguly declared at 657 for seven, and Harbhajan Singh and Tendulkar combined to send the visitors packing for 212. India had somehow pulled off a miracle, winning by 171 runs to square the series and going on to complete a fairytale series triumph with a tense victory in the decider in Chennai.

An epic

That epic second Test in 2001, between March 11 and 15, unfolded at the theatre of dreams – and sometimes nightmares, too

– that is Kolkata's Eden Gardens. On day one of the game, Harbhajan became the first Indian to take a Test hat-trick. On day four, Laxman went past Gavaskar's 236*. And on day five, India rewrote history by becoming only the third team to win a Test after being forced to follow-on.

Laxman, Dravid and Harbhajan played several other Tests at the Eden and enjoyed stellar successes, but not against Australia for the rest of their careers even though the Aussies toured India in 2004, 2008 and 2010 when the trio was still active. Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma and R. Ashwin, all retired from Test cricket, didn't play Australia at the Eden at all. And now, it looks as if Jasprit Bumrah, acknowledged as the greatest all-format bowler of certainly his and potentially any generation, will join that elite list.

Welcome to the strange, quirky, predictably predictable world of Indian cricket. Eden Gardens is in good company, let's not forget. One of Laxman's less celebrated but no less magical knocks came at Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium, also against Australia, in November 2004. It was the last match of a four-fixture faceoff; India trailed 0-2, having surrendered a Test series at home to the Antipodeans for the first time in more than three decades. Despite Shane Warne sitting out the 'dead rubber' on a minefield, they were rolled over for 104, to which the Aussies replied with 203. A 99-run lead on a surface of that nature was pure gold but Laxman and Tendulkar put on their dancing shoes, producing a veritable feast during which they made it seem as if they were batting on a shirtfront.

During a third-wicket alliance of 91, they drove Ricky Ponting ragged. Tendulkar weighed in with 55 of the very best, Laxman was subliminally brilliant during his 69. Even though Michael Clarke (6/9) sparked a spectacular collapse of six for 23, India defended 107 with tigerish zeal, Harbhajan and Murali Kartik bowling them to a 13-run victory with five for 29. Oh, what drama.

The 171-run heist in 2001 remains the last time India took on Australia at the Eden; the teams haven't also met each other in a Test at the Wankhede since the 13-run jailbreak in 2004. So much for the weight of history, of celebrating 'traditional' centres, of doing everything to keep Test cricket 'alive and vibrant', as the Board of Control for Cricket in India loves to point out time and again.

That it's not enough to merely provide lip service to maintaining the primacy of the five-day game has never been more apparent in the last few days, since the venues for the five-Test home series for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy beginning next January were announced. This is the first time since 1979-80 that the Aussies will be playing at least five Tests in India; of the one-time marquee Test centres, only Chennai's M.A. Chidambaram Stadium has been considered worthy of staging a match of this import and pedigree. The others bestowed the privilege of playing host are Nagpur, Ranchi, Guwahati and Ahmedabad.

In the last few years, ever since the sprawling Narendra Modi Stadium replaced the old Sardar Patel Stadium in

Audiences for Tests have been dwindling in India for a while now, making it imperative to figure out which are the centres where there is still a demand for the red-ball format

Motera in 2021, Ahmedabad has become a near-permanent stop in all big-ticket series/competitions. It's hosted several Tests, among them against England and Australia, and it was where the final of the 50-over World Cup in 2023 and the T20 World Cup earlier this month were conducted. One can understand the desire to take World Cup and IPL finals to a ground that can house between 103,000 and 125,000 fans – depending on who one talks to – but whether its vastness alone is enough for Test matches to repeatedly be held there is another matter altogether.

New entrant

Now, jostling for pre-eminence is the Assam Cricket Association Stadium in Guwahati, which last November became India's 30th Test venue. By no stretch of the imagination is Guwahati a 'traditional' cricketing centre. There is a huge clamour for white-ball fireworks, like it is in several non-Tier 1 cricketing venues in the country, but the patronage for the inaugural Test at the ground, against recently crowned World Test champions South Africa, was worse than disappointing. For Guwahati to be given the opportunity to hold another Test against one of the top teams in the world is a massive surprise, but only when you disregard the fact that the current secretary of the BCCI hails from that part of the country. Power centres in sports associations will inevitably shift and be redefined, but should staging centres follow suit depending on who occupies the corridors of power? What happened to the acclaimed rotation policy aimed at equitable distribution of matches across the length and the breadth of the country? Given India's size, the immense revenue generated by the BCCI and the distribution of much of that revenue to its member associations to improve cricketing infrastructure, among other things, India boast a plethora of

world-class stadiums. The rotation system was introduced to ensure that everyone got their fair share of matches but now it's a system that exists either only on paper or in one's imagination because clearly, in reality, it has been given the heave-ho.

Audiences for Test matches have been dwindling in India for a while now, which makes it imperative for those entrusted with deciding which matches are played where to figure out which are the centres where there is still a demand for the red-ball format. There are enough limited-overs internationals – meaningful or otherwise – to be distributed to the others. It is essential that Test cricket isn't spread thin by doling out its staging rights to all and sundry. How will Shubman Gill and Bumrah, Steve Smith and Pat Cummins, be energised by having to play high-stakes, high-profile Tests in front of less than 5,000 spectators, several of whom have been ferried through inducements rather than out of a great love for the game? Are we so caught up in the game of one-upmanship that the actual game becomes a casualty?

There is much to commend the BCCI for. The number of matches it conducts annually – and seamlessly – across genders and age groups is staggering. It hasn't been miserly with its vast coffers, taking care of not just its members (vote banks, if you like, though developments over the last decade have precluded the need for elections in recent AGMs) but also of the players – both international and domestic. It hasn't been so blinded by the lure of the lucre that it has neglected the grassroots. It's credit to the governing body in the country that it has managed to attract and hold the interest of several legends, including Ravi Shastri, Dravid and Laxman, among others, in coaching and administrative roles with an eye on both the present and the future.

For all its commitment to the sport and its practitioners, it has still been a soft target for many with an axe to grind. But it must also acknowledge that one mustn't just be fair but must also be seen to be fair. And surely, there isn't a lot fair in cricket-crazy fans in Kolkata and Mumbai waiting 25 and 22 years respectively, unsuccessfully, to welcome an India vs Australia Test match?

THE GIST

▼ In the last few years, ever since the sprawling Narendra Modi Stadium replaced the old Sardar Patel Stadium in Motera in 2021, Ahmedabad has become a near-permanent stop in all big-ticket series/competitions

▼ Now, jostling for pre-eminence is the Assam Cricket Association Stadium in Guwahati, which last November became India's 30th Test venue. By no stretch of the imagination is Guwahati a 'traditional' cricketing centre

▼ There are enough limited-overs internationals – meaningful or otherwise – to be distributed to the others. It is essential that Test cricket isn't spread thin by doling out its staging rights to all and sundry

Eden Gardens and Wankhede.
FILE PHOTOS: V.V. KRISHNAN



Secretive jungle cats need habitats outside protected areas: study

A new study's finding that jungle cats use agricultural landscapes aligns with previous knowledge of the species, in and around farms, these cats keep rodent populations in check, thus 'protecting' crops; however, these landscapes lie outside protected areas and harbour several threats, including fragmented habitats and speeding vehicles

Ananya Singh

Jungle cats (*Felis chaus*) are found across diverse habitats, from grasslands and wetlands to deserts. They are present across Asia, with large populations in India and Nepal, among others. The IUCN Red List lists the species as being of 'least concern'.

This has led to a "misconception that they are doing fine", Kathan Bandyopadhyay, a postdoctoral research associate at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, said.

Jungle cats' populations are in fact considered to be shrinking. In India, they are protected under Schedule II of the Indian Wildlife (Protection) Act 1972, which means hunting or trading them is illegal.

Despite being the most widespread of India's small cats, jungle cats are understudied and have received little conservation attention relative to larger carnivores such as tigers and leopards.

Conservation baseline

This animal – with a white muzzle, yellow irises, large ears ending in black tufts, and the sometimes faint striping on its long legs – avoids dense forests and heavily-modified landscapes, preferring agro-pastoral and open habitats, according to a new study based on the largest dataset on the species in India.

The study was published in *Scientific Reports*, and provides a baseline for future conservation planning.

"Until now, we didn't know about their population status or how they are responding to several habitat and climatic covariates," Dr. Bandyopadhyay, who undertook this research as a PhD student at the University of Wyoming, said.

The team found human pressure to be the foremost factor influencing where jungle cats live and that while they can tolerate moderate levels of human disturbance, they avoid densely populated areas.

"Our results highlight the importance of agro-pastoral landscapes in conserving wildlife beyond protected areas, especially as urbanisation continues to expand," Dr. Bandyopadhyay said.

'An important analysis'

To estimate how many jungle cats were in India and where, the team compiled camera-trap records from more than 26,000 locations across India. These records were a 'bycatch' of tiger surveys and were supplemented with data from previous studies, radio-collared individuals, and the authors' personal observations. The researchers then included one camera-trap record every 25 sq. km, one radio-collar data point from



A jungle cat in Rajasthan, 2021. KANDUKURU NAGARJUN

every 5 sq. km, plus all secondary data (from outside protected areas). Then they used machine-learning to model suitable habitats using the final dataset of over 6,000 records.

The team combined these results with sex-specific home range data to estimate a countrywide population of over 3 lakh jungle cats, with at least 1.57 lakh and at most 4.59 lakh individuals. "It's an estimate. It gives you a limit within which the cat is likely to be," Yadvendradev Jhala, senior scientist at the National Centre for Biological Sciences and the study's co-author and co-supervisor, said.

Across 21 States with suitable habitats, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Odisha were estimated to support the largest populations.

The study is an "important analysis" and has "strengthened the observation that the jungle cat is tightly associated with open natural ecosystems, currently under enormous threat of conversion to other forms of land use, such as built-up areas and large-scale linear infrastructure like highways," Shomita Mukherjee, senior principal scientist at the Salim Ali Centre for Ornithology and Natural History, Coimbatore, and a member of the IUCN/SSC Cat Specialists Group, said. Dr. Mukherjee was not a part of the study.

Ideal landscapes

Per the study, jungle cats prefer warm, semi-arid regions that are seasonally dry, with moderate rainfall and canopy cover. Their predicted hotspots lie in India's east rather than in the drier west.



Our results highlight the importance of agro-pastoral landscapes in conserving wildlife beyond protected areas, especially as urbanisation continues to expand

KATHAN BANDYOPADHYAY
Postdoctoral research associate at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

India needs land policies that recognise the ecological value of open ecosystems, Dr. Mukherjee added.

According to her, the finding that jungle cats use agricultural landscapes aligns with previous knowledge of the species. In and around farms, these cats keep rodent populations in check, thus 'protecting' crops.

However, these landscapes lie outside protected areas and harbour several threats, including fragmented habitats, speeding vehicles on roads, and poaching, according to the study.

It also pointed to a potential threat from hybridisation with domestic cats, which could compromise their genetic lineage, although Dr. Bandyopadhyay and Dr. Mukherjee cautioned that this idea doesn't have enough evidence.

Another key threat is the stray dog population, which "acts as a source of wildlife diseases and kleptoparasitism – that means snatching kills from jungle cats and other carnivores," Dr. Bandyopadhyay said.

Per the study, stray dogs could share

foraging spaces with other livestock, so where there is livestock, there could be the risk of these canines as well.

A policy for small cats

According to Dr. Mukherjee, the study's strengths lie in its large spatial coverage and sample size, although she added that jungle cats from Sikkim had been left out and that the population figures were based on a "meagre dataset of a few radio-collared individuals in just a couple of locations".

"Yet this should not be seen as a limitation but an effort to get the best out of data currently available," she added.

Dr. Bandyopadhyay said the records from Sikkim were sporadic and insufficiently viable for the models.

Scientists still have a great number of unknowns, including jungle cats' denning sites, litter sizes, ranging patterns, densities, and diets.

Small cats are generally hard to study because they are nocturnal and secretive. Public awareness is also low, and few organisations have been willing to fund more study.

Going forward, Dr. Jhala said, there is a need to plan wildlife passageways alongside infrastructure development in agro-pastoral and open habitats. "When roads pass through a tiger or elephant corridor, there is a policy to try and mitigate those. But when they pass through agro-pastoral landscapes, we don't plan for it even though these areas support rich biodiversity," he said.

(Ananya Singh is an independent journalist. ananyaasingh.as@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Despite being the most widespread of India's small cats, jungle cats are understudied and have received little conservation attention relative to larger carnivores

According to a new study, the estimated countrywide population of jungle cats is over 3 lakh

Jungle cats avoids dense forests and heavily-modified landscapes, preferring agro-pastoral and open habitats

BIG SHOT



A handout picture taken in 2023 off Dominique Island shows female sperm whales holding a newborn calf above water until it can swim on its own. Last week, U.S.-based Project CETI researchers reported they had witnessed the rare spectacle of a wild sperm whale being born, immediately carried to the surface by members of its clan. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

exRNA: on a mission

Vasudevan Mukunth

In a study published in the journal *Clean Water* on March 28, scientists reported that extracellular RNA (exRNA) from bacteria can persist in disinfected drinking water. They also found that by studying the exRNA, they could figure out what the bacteria were doing just before they were damaged or killed, releasing the exRNA. This way, the scientists could figure out which survival strategies worked for the bacteria – which can be used to make better disinfectants.

exRNA is RNA that exists outside cells, in body fluids such as blood, saliva, urine, and cerebrospinal fluid. For decades, scientists believed RNA only functioned inside the cell and assumed that if RNA 'leaked' out, enzymes in the blood would destroy it. However, researchers have found that cells in fact intentionally 'export' RNA.

To survive outside the cell, exRNA travels in its own molecular containers that prevent enzymes from breaking it down before it reaches its destination.

exRNA has been found to be part of a sophisticated long-distance communication system. A cell releases RNA to deliver instructions to another cell elsewhere in the body, changing how it behaves or which genes it activates. This process helps coordinate responses in the immune system, tissue repair, and development. However, cancer cells can also release exRNA to



An illustration of the RNA called mRNA. GETTY IMAGES

promote tumour growth.

The discovery of exRNA changed modern medicine. For instance, just by testing a patient's blood or other body fluids, doctors can identify specific RNA patterns linked to cancer or heart disease.



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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Death toll due to extreme weather in Afghanistan

17 Severe flooding, a landslide and thunderstorms in parts of Afghanistan have left 17 people dead and 26 injured over the last 24 hours, authorities said on Sunday, the latest casualties from extreme weather in the country this season. AP

Artificial water harvesting structures in India in 11 years

50 in lakh. Nearly 50 lakh artificial water harvesting structures have been created under the 'Jal Sanchay Abhiyan' and 70,000 lakes were made under the 'Amrit Sarovar Abhiyan' in the last 11 years, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday. PTI

Worth of deals secured by Ethiopia at investment conference

13 in \$ billion. Ethiopia has secured \$13 billion worth of investment deals, the state investment commission said. Like other frontier economies in Africa, the East African nation has been seeking to boost foreign direct investment. REUTERS

Maoists surrendered before Odisha Police since January 2025

77 Odisha DGP Y.B. Khurania on Sunday said 77 Maoists have surrendered before police in the State between January 2025 and March this year. He also said 27 Maoists have been killed in exchanges of fire with security forces since January 2025. PTI

Stolen mobile phones recovered by Delhi Police

100 The Delhi Police said on Sunday that the Crime Branch has traced and returned over 100 lost or stolen mobile phones to their rightful owners in a coordinated drive. PTI
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On Maharashtra's anti-conversion Bill

How does the 60-day notice requirement work? Who can file a complaint under the law? What penalties does the Bill prescribe for violations? When can a marriage be declared null and void? Why have civil rights groups raised concerns? How has the State justified the need for the law?

EXPLAINER

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit

The story so far:

The Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026, was passed by both Houses of the Maharashtra Legislature a few days ago. The Bill has been opposed by several civil society organisations, which have expressed apprehensions about the State encroaching on the personal liberty of its citizens. They claim that the Bill violates the fundamental rights enshrined in the Constitution.

What is the Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Bill?

The Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026, has been defined as “a Bill to provide for protection of right to freedom of religion and prohibition of unlawful conversion from one religion to another, and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.” It aims to prohibit conversions carried out through allurements, misrepresentation, force, undue influence, coercion, or any other fraudulent means.

It lays down an elaborate procedure for conversion, including a declaration of intent with a 60-day prior notice. A post-conversion declaration is also required.

What are the key provisions?

Under the proposed Act, it is mandatory for the police officer to register a complaint even if the relatives of the converted person approach them. The complainant may be the converted person, or their parents, siblings, or any other person related by blood, marriage, or adoption.

Any marriage solemnised solely for unlawful conversion shall be declared null



Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis says conversions causing disturbance to public order in the State. PTI

and void by the court, on a petition filed by either party. Any child born out of such a marriage or relationship belongs to the religion of the mother before such a marriage or relationship. The child will have succession rights to the property of both parents as per the prevailing laws. Maintenance will have to be given, and custody will remain with the mother unless decided otherwise by a court.

What punishment is proposed under the Bill?

Punishments for violation include imprisonment of up to 10 years and a fine of up to ₹7 lakh. Offences under the Bill will be cognisable and non-bailable.

The offence of unlawful conversion is punishable with up to seven years' imprisonment and a fine of ₹1 lakh. If the person converted is a minor, a woman, a person of unsound mind, or belongs to the Scheduled Castes or the Scheduled Tribes, the punishment increases to seven years' imprisonment and a fine of ₹5 lakh.

Mass conversions will attract similar penalties. Repeat offenders may face

imprisonment of up to 10 years and a fine of ₹7 lakh. Institutions found guilty of forced conversions may face cancellation of registration and withdrawal of government aid or grants. Office-bearers may also face imprisonment of up to seven years and a fine of ₹5 lakh. Victims will be entitled to rehabilitation, maintenance, and custody of children.

What are the concerns raised?

Concerns have been raised on several grounds, including the lack of empirical evidence to justify such legislation, the social implications of the 60-day prior notice requirement, the curtailment of the individual's right to freedom of religion, and administrative overreach into personal matters.

Last year, the State government appointed a seven-member special committee under the Director General of Police to study legal issues related to religious conversion. Its report has not yet been made public, though the government has said that the committee recommended enacting a special law.

Opposition leaders have termed the Bill 'regressive' and alleged that it targets a particular community.

Since offences under the Bill are non-bailable, civil rights activists have expressed concerns that it may target interfaith marriages and minority religious practices. They also fear the intervention of families and vigilante groups in pressuring consenting adult couples.

“In any case, this places State surveillance over deeply personal decisions related to faith and marriage,” a civil rights activist said.

Bureaucrats have also raised administrative concerns. “There is no established certification system for religions right now. We will have to develop a system. This is an administrative concern. We will have to look into the models that other States have developed. An entire gamut of administrative mechanisms will have to be created,” a senior IAS officer said, adding that the revenue authorities will now come into the picture for matters of marriage and personal laws, which were managed by the civil courts so far. “Personal law is increasingly becoming a matter of administrative authorities. This creates a complication for marriages out of free will, too,” an IAS officer said.

How has the State government addressed these apprehensions?

The government has said that the right to freedom of religion is not absolute. It has also been said that the cases of forcible religious conversions have been increasing in the State, and that the government does not currently have effective laws to tackle the law and order issues arising out of them.

“These instances are causing disturbance to public order in the State and are affecting social harmony,” Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has said.

THE GIST

The Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Bill, 2026, seeks to prohibit unlawful religious conversions and mandates procedures such as a 60-day prior notice and post-conversion declaration, with violations attracting imprisonment, fines, and non-bailable offences.

The Bill has drawn criticism from civil society and Opposition leaders, who argue it curtails personal liberty, enables State interference in faith and marriage, and may target interfaith relationships, while the government defends it as necessary to address forcible conversions and maintain public order.

Pak. as U.S. mediator with Iran recalls Nixon's China outreach

Washington's decision is shaped by Pakistan's proximity, its ties with Tehran, and its lack of ties with Israel

WORLD INSIGHT

Suhasini Haidar

Pakistan's emergence as Washington's choice as a mediator in talks with Iran can be explained in a number of ways. Since Operation Sindoor in May 2025, U.S. President Donald Trump has been flattered by Pakistan's description of him as a “peacemaker”, and he has reportedly built a personal rapport with Pakistan's Field Marshal General Asim Munir and Pakistani PM Shehbaz Sharif, meeting them several times.

In particular, Mr. Trump hosted General Munir to lunch at the White House in June last year, amidst the last U.S.-Israeli strikes, in an effort reportedly to ensure that Pakistan would not support Iran militarily.

Pakistan's offer of a critical minerals deal to the U.S. and decision to join the Gaza Board of Peace (BoP) have also helped forge the relationship.

For Iran, Pakistan's advantage over many other possible mediators is not only its proximity but also the fact that it does not recognise Israel, and thus is not

amenable to concerns or inputs from the Benjamin Netanyahu government. This may suit Mr. Trump as well, who has reportedly conveyed a 15-point proposal to the government in Tehran, which it hopes will lead to a ceasefire.

Cold War precedent

However, Washington's decision to engage Pakistan as a facilitator for talks may also be rooted in history, given Islamabad and a different General's role in facilitating U.S. talks with China 55 years ago, at the height of the Cold War.

At that time, U.S. President Richard Nixon had begun to work on his plan to open up relations with Beijing (the U.S. still formally recognised Taiwan as the Republic of China), but direct Sino-U.S. Ambassadorial talks had floundered. Pakistan was not the first option, as he and his National Security Advisor, Henry Kissinger, considered others.

Mao Zedong, Chairman of the Chinese Communist Party and leader of the People's Republic of China (PRC), turned down the idea of France as he wanted a “non-Western” channel. The Warsaw track fell apart after two rounds of talks between U.S. and Chinese officials, as Mr. Mao protested U.S. attacks on Cambodia,

which were part of a U.S. Army effort to cut off supplies to Vietnamese troops.

While Mr. Nixon's need for partners in Asia, as the Vietnam War drained the U.S., drove him to seek China, Sino-Soviet tensions gave Mr. Mao a reason to engage with Washington.

The U.S. tried Romania, working through President Nicolae Ceausescu to reach out to the Chinese government, but hit an unexpected block. “We went to the Romanians, thinking they were most independent of the East Europeans and they were communists and therefore the Chinese would like that. Turns out the one group the Chinese didn't trust were Communists,” Mr. Kissinger told journalist Tom Brokaw decades later, explaining that Beijing feared Romanian officials would divulge details to the Kremlin, which would attempt to sabotage the process.

By then, Mr. Nixon had also established a secret channel to the PRC's leadership through Pakistani President General Agha Mohammad Yahya Khan. “In Nixon's view, Khan was an attractive intermediary since he had good relations with the leaders of the U.S. and the PRC, and he provided a means to circumvent the U.S. Department of State, which Nixon feared

might oppose or publicise his initiative,” records the U.S. Office of the Historian, in a note about the China opening.

According to one account, the White House sent two identical notes, one through President Yahya Khan and another through President Ceausescu, but it was Pakistan's Ambassador to Washington, Agha Hilaly, who returned with a response first, a whole month before his Romanian counterpart did. In July 1971, Mr. Kissinger travelled to Pakistan, where he feigned an illness and was taken to Nathiagali (near Murree), away from the eyes of the press corps and even his own diplomats in Islamabad. Gen. Khan had arranged for a commercial PIA flight 707 to take him from Rawalpindi to Peking (Beijing) for talks.

Mr. Kissinger, who had been hosted by Indian officials a day before, reportedly used “Delhi belly” as his excuse to ensure a 64-hour getaway that included meeting Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai and others in China for the first time. Planning for Mr. Nixon's visit to China in February 1972, which he referred to as the ‘week that changed the world’, had begun.

Cost of back-channel diplomacy

The event had deep and lasting impacts on South Asia as well. Mr. Nixon's preoccupation with his back-channel to China and deep-seated rancour against India led him to turn a blind eye as Pakistan's troops unleashed a genocide on Bengalis in East Pakistan. On March 25, 1971, the Pakistan Army launched Operation Searchlight, killing an estimated three million over the next nine months, according to the Bangladesh government.

On April 28, 1971, Mr. Kissinger sent a

memo to Mr. Nixon detailing options before the U.S.: (1) support Pakistan militarily; (2) maintain neutrality; (3) help “Yahya achieve a negotiated settlement”.

Mr. Nixon's instructions, despite desperate telegrams from the U.S. Embassy in Dhaka about the violence, were clear. “To all hands, don't squeeze Yahya at this time,” he wrote, checking option (3).

The crackdown led lakhs of refugees to flee to India, spurring India's support to the Mukti Bahini movement led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, who had won Pakistani General elections in December 1970 but was imprisoned. The India-Pakistan war followed, where the U.S. even attempted to threaten India by dispatching a naval fleet, but ultimately, Bangladesh was formed by December that year. India's perspective was shaped by the 20-year Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation signed in August 1971.

Pakistan has played the role several times. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar reminded opposition MPs at an all-party meeting last week, when they criticised the government's failure to play a bigger role in the crisis. Since 1981, Pakistan has represented Tehran through its Embassy in Washington's “Iran Interests Section”. During the two-decade-long U.S. military intervention in Afghanistan, Pakistan also acted as a mediator with the Taliban. Islamabad was the venue for Quadrilateral talks between Egypt-Pakistan-Turkiye-Saudi Foreign Ministers on Sunday, and could host a U.S. delegation this week. Much depends on whether the Iranian leadership, which accused the U.S. of planning a ground invasion, will join the talks.

